

TCG design videos: key points for Dark Charterlands

18 of 18 videos processed. Each video was summarized by the media-flow-critique-youtube pipeline (`run_single_video_ollama.py`, mistral-small: timestamped, transcript-grounded key points), then read against the Dark Charterlands design brief by `apply_lens.py`, and each takeaway was filed into a design area from its own content (a separate pass without the brief, so the brief couldn't bias the filing). Timestamps link to the moment in the video.

How to read this: the key points are grounded in each video's transcript. The *For us* lines are a local model's suggestions for the team to weigh, not decisions. Some are generic, and a few suggest things our design deliberately avoids (for example, random events or more Seasons). Check anything that matters against the linked timestamp.

Regenerate: `python run_pipeline.py && python apply_lens.py`.

Headline lesson per video

Video	Views	Lesson
Magic: the Gathering: 20 Years, 20 Lessons Learned (GDC 2016) (Mark Rosewater (Magic))	1,083,891	The most important lesson from this video is that understanding human nature, aesthetics, and emotional resonance is crucial for creating a compelling and engaging game experience, and that small changes and details can have a significant impact on gameplay.
Power Creep in Hearthstone (Extra Credits)	823,710	The team should prioritize understanding and maintaining a healthy power curve to prevent unintentional power creep, which could disrupt the game's balance and longevity.
First Move Advantage - How to Balance Turn-Based Games (Extra Credits)	778,958	The team should be aware of the first move advantage and implement mechanics to mitigate it, especially since Dark Charterlands is a developed-resource game.
The Delta of Randomness - Can You Balance for RNG? (Extra Credits)	539,644	The team should focus on balancing the Delta of Randomness to ensure that exciting moments in Dark Charterlands are created without making the game feel arbitrary, and provide strategic options to mitigate or eliminate randomness.
Collectible Games III: What Makes a Good TCG or CCG? (Extra Credits)	376,192	The team should focus on designing Dark Charterlands to be a dynamic and evolving game that encourages players to explore different strategies and adapt to new cards, ensuring a rich and engaging gameplay experience.
Designing MARVEL SNAP (GDC 2023) (Ben Brode (Marvel Snap))	262,536	The most important lesson from this video is the importance of balancing complexity and depth in game design, ensuring that the game is accessible to new players while offering strategic depth for experienced players.

Video	Views	Lesson
Designing my own Trading Card Game (Ten Hundred)	238,325	Engage with the community early and often to gather feedback and shape the game's design, while ensuring the core loop is engaging and the onboarding process is smooth.
The History of Roguelike Deckbuilders (Extra Credits)	168,918	The team should study the evolution of card games and the innovations that have shaped the genre, particularly focusing on costing, balance, and onboarding to ensure Dark Charterlands stands out in the market.
Slay the Spire: Metrics Driven Design and Balance (GDC 2019) (Anthony Giovannetti (Mega Crit))	163,220	The most important lesson from this video is the critical role of iterative design, extensive playtesting, and data-driven decision-making in creating a balanced and engaging game.
Hearthstone: How to Create an Immersive User Interface (GDC 2015) (Hearthstone team)	151,897	The most important lesson for the team is to focus on creating a cohesive and immersive experience through a clear guiding muse and an iterative design process that emphasizes the physicality of the game elements.
Balancing Mechanics for Your Card Game's Unique Power Curve (GDC 2018) (Dylan Mayo (The Pokemon Company))	146,128	The power curve of a card game is heavily influenced by its costing and resource management systems, and understanding these dynamics is crucial for balancing and designing meaningful gameplay.
Hearthstone: 10 Bits of Design Wisdom (GDC 2014) (Eric Dodds (Hearthstone))	134,456	The most important lesson from this video is the significance of designing for immediate fun and accessibility, while also considering the emotional impact of gameplay mechanics on players.
Designing Race for the Galaxy (GDC 2018) (Tom Lehmann)	104,774	The most important lesson from this video is the significance of player agency and strategic depth in game design, achieved through mechanisms like simultaneous action selection and economic principles that enhance decision-making.
Luck in Games (ITU Copenhagen) (Richard Garfield (Magic))	62,708	The team should carefully balance luck and skill in Dark Charterlands, introducing luck to make the game accessible and engaging, while gradually reducing it as the player base matures to emphasize skill.
PAX Dev 2018 Keynote (Ben Brode)	46,177	The most important lesson from this video is the significance of having a clear and shared vision among the team, especially when designing complex systems like Community Charters, and the importance of engaging directly with the community to build trust and manage expectations.
From Concept to Card: How to Design an Epic TCG Set (Rempton Games)	41,534	The most important lesson for the team is the iterative nature of TCG design, emphasizing the need for a well-structured design skeleton, continuous playtesting, and a focus on unique and memorable themes to create a balanced and engaging set.
What Can Video Games Learn from Collectible Card Games? (GDC 2018) (Skaff Elias)	14,654	The most important lesson from this video is the need to balance design and business considerations, ensuring that the game remains engaging and valuable to players over the long term, which is crucial for a high-depth strategy game like Dark Charterlands.
Designing TCG Resource Systems (Steve Sekula (TCG Design Theory))	5,963	The most important lesson from this video is the critical role of a well-designed resource system in enhancing the depth, balance, and accessibility of a trading card game, which the team should apply to the Seals system in Dark Charterlands.

Takeaways by design area

Sorted by relevance to Dark Charterlands (high first). Low-relevance takeaways are in the per-video section only.

Draft & set structure

- **Small changes can have a significant impact on game design.** (high). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\)](#), 53:05
 - *For us:* The team should be aware that small changes in Dark Charterlands can have a significant impact on the game. Even minor adjustments to mechanics or rules can lead to radically different gameplay experiences.
- **Collectible card games (CCGs) and trading card games (TCGs) offer dynamic and evolving gameplay experiences as players acquire new cards.** (high). [Extra Credits](#), 0:33
 - *For us:* The team should design Dark Charterlands to encourage players to explore different tactics and strategies, ensuring that the game remains dynamic and engaging over time. This can be achieved by regularly introducing new cards and mechanics that force players to adapt their strategies. The game should also provide a variety of playstyles and deck-building options to keep players engaged and motivated to collect new cards.
- **The design skeleton is a crucial outline that helps determine which cards to design and how everything fits together.** (high). [Rempton Games](#), 5:26
 - *For us:* The team should create a design skeleton that outlines the structure of the set, ensuring that all major factions and card types are represented. This includes designing cards at a range of different costs, especially at common and uncommon levels, to ensure a good curve. The design skeleton should also include spots for specific details known to be needed in the set, such as new mechanics and top-down tropes.
- **Keeping objects interesting over the long term and avoiding complexity and power creep are important for maintaining player engagement.** (high). [Skaff Elias](#), 46:13
 - *For us:* The team should focus on keeping objects interesting over the long term and avoiding complexity and power creep. This is important for maintaining player engagement and ensuring that the game remains balanced and enjoyable over time.
- **The speaker is focusing on the desert biome for the initial phase of development.** (medium). [Ten Hundred](#), 3:58
 - *For us:* Start with a limited set of factions and archetypes to ease players into the game. Consider how the desert biome's unique play style can inform the distinct strategies of different factions in Dark Charterlands.

- **The video emphasizes the importance of a unique and memorable core theme for a TCG set, which can be either mechanical (bottom-up) or flavorful (top-down).** (medium). [Rempton Games, 1:02](#)
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that the core theme of Dark Charterlands is unique and memorable, tying into both the mechanical and flavorful aspects of the game. This will help players understand and engage with the game's world and mechanics more easily. The team should also consider having around three major themes, including at least one mechanical and one flavorful theme that tie into each other.

Multiplayer & politics

- **The game Race features simultaneous action selection, which can lead to bluffing, gambling, and strategic interactions among players.** (medium). [Tom Lehmann, 29:41](#)
 - *For us:* Leverage simultaneous play to speed up multiplayer games. Ensure that the game flow is smooth by minimizing synchronization points, such as during the CONTEST phase where Marches resolve in parallel.

Resource system

- **The game's design incorporates economic principles, such as opportunity cost, to enhance strategic decision-making.** (high). [Tom Lehmann, 10:54](#)
 - *For us:* Incorporate economic principles like opportunity cost into the design. For example, make players discard cards to pay for new ones, emphasizing the value of each card in their hand. This can add depth to decision-making in the MUSTER phase.
- **The resource system in Gem Blenders is integral to its gameplay, allowing players to unlock powerful abilities by blending gems.** (high). [Steve Sekula \(TCG Design Theory\), 6:16](#)
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that the Seals (resources) in Dark Charterlands are integral to unlocking powerful abilities and transformations, similar to how gems are used in Gem Blenders. This will add depth to the gameplay and make the resource system a key feature.
- **The design of Gem Blenders prioritizes elegance and ease of resource acquisition.** (high). [Steve Sekula \(TCG Design Theory\), 19:38](#)
 - *For us:* The team should design the Seals system to be elegant and easy to acquire, balancing the complexity of managing multiple resources. This will help maintain a smooth gameplay experience.
- **Digital and physical trading card games have different resource systems that affect gameplay.** (high). [Steve Sekula \(TCG Design Theory\), 20:16](#)
 - *For us:* The team should leverage the physical nature of Dark Charterlands to create a more impactful resource system, ensuring that the management of Seals is engaging and tactile.
- **The design of resource systems in trading card games can significantly impact accessibility and marketability.** (high). [Steve Sekula \(TCG Design Theory\), 22:26](#)
 - *For us:* The team should design the Seals system to be accessible to new players, ensuring that the initial packs provide enough resources to build a functional deck without requiring too many additional cards.

- **Gameplay benefits should take priority over thematic consistency.** (high). [Steve Sekula \(TCG Design Theory\), 36:17](#)
 - *For us:* The team should prioritize gameplay benefits over thematic consistency when designing the Seals system, ensuring that the resource management is enjoyable and strategic.
- **Gem Blenders' resource system is designed to be unique and thematic, combining familiar elements to create a distinctive gameplay experience.** (high). [Steve Sekula \(TCG Design Theory\), 52:06](#)
 - *For us:* The team should design the Seals system to be both thematic and familiar, combining elements that players are accustomed to while allowing for a high degree of creativity and flexibility in deck-building.
- **The hero power in Hearthstone helps smooth out the mana curve.** (medium). [Dylan Mayo \(The Pokemon Company\), 6:36](#)
 - *For us:* Consider adding a mechanism similar to Hearthstone's hero power to help players use all their resources each turn, smoothing out the resource curve and adding strategic depth.
- **Magic: The Gathering has a more complex mana system compared to Hearthstone, allowing for greater granularity in card balancing.** (medium). [Dylan Mayo \(The Pokemon Company\), 10:16](#)
 - *For us:* Explore different resource management systems to add complexity and granularity to card balancing. This could involve using different types of resources or requiring specific resources for certain cards.
- **Different card games have unique resource management systems that affect their power curves.** (medium). [Dylan Mayo \(The Pokemon Company\), 25:02](#)
 - *For us:* Explore different resource management systems to create a unique power curve. Consider how resources are generated and used, and how this affects the balance and strategy of the game.
- **Gem Blenders uses a resource system that is familiar yet different, drawing inspiration from games like Magic and Pokémon.** (medium). [Steve Sekula \(TCG Design Theory\), 12:27](#)
 - *For us:* The team should aim to make the Seals system in Dark Charterlands familiar yet unique, drawing inspiration from other TCGs to make it accessible to new players while also offering a fresh experience.
- **Thematic consistency is crucial for a game's resource system.** (medium). [Steve Sekula \(TCG Design Theory\), 32:13](#)
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that the Seals system in Dark Charterlands blends well with the game's overall theme and mechanics, making it a natural and elegant part of the gameplay experience.

Costing & balance

- **Power creep in games can occur unintentionally due to the complexity of game design, particularly in collectible card games like Hearthstone.** (high). [Extra Credits, 1:04](#)
 - *For us:* The team should be vigilant about the power level of new cards, especially those with unique abilities, to avoid setting a new baseline that could lead to power creep. They should regularly review the power curve of the game and ensure that new cards fit within the established design space. This is particularly important given the game's high-depth strategy expectation and the use of a costing formula based on MetaZoo's rate.
- **Understanding the power curve is crucial for identifying and mitigating power creep in games.** (high). [Extra Credits, 1:32](#)
 - *For us:* The team should create and maintain a power curve for Dark Charterlands, plotting the Influence (power) and cost of each card. This will help identify cards that spike too high or too low, allowing for better balance and mitigation of power creep. Regularly updating this curve with new releases will be crucial.
- **The cost and power of cards in Hearthstone are balanced to create a unique power curve.** (high). [Dylan Mayo \(The Pokemon Company\), 2:42](#)
 - *For us:* Ensure that more expensive cards in Dark Charterlands provide significantly more power to justify their cost, maintaining a non-linear power curve. This encourages dynamic gameplay and meaningful choices throughout the game.
- **The power of a card is not just about its raw stats but also about its cost-to-power ratio.** (high). [Dylan Mayo \(The Pokemon Company\), 7:46](#)
 - *For us:* Consider the cost-to-power ratio when designing cards. A card's true power is not just about its raw stats but also about its effectiveness in various situations. This ratio is crucial for evaluating a card's balance.
- **The granularity of card costs and stats significantly impacts game balance and design.** (high). [Dylan Mayo \(The Pokemon Company\), 21:21](#)
 - *For us:* Pay close attention to the granularity of card costs and stats. Small numbers can significantly impact game balance, so consider increasing base values to allow for finer adjustments.
- **The game design philosophy emphasizes strategic tension between incremental gains and big combos.** (high). [Tom Lehmann, 36:05](#)
 - *For us:* Create strategic tension between incremental gains and big combos. Design cards and abilities that offer both small, incremental advantages and powerful combos that require strategic planning to execute. This can be integrated into the EDICTS phase where one-shot Edicts can provide significant advantages.
- **Resource systems are essential for balancing and adding depth to trading card games.** (high). [Steve Sekula \(TCG Design Theory\), 10:12](#)
 - *For us:* The team should design the Seals system to allow for varied card costs and effects, creating the necessary variance and strategic depth for players to enjoy. This will help balance the game and make it more engaging.

- **The power curves in Magic: The Gathering and Hearthstone differ significantly due to their respective mana systems.** (medium). [Dylan Mayo \(The Pokemon Company\), 11:40](#)
 - *For us:* Design the resource system in Dark Charterlands to influence the power curve. For example, if resources are harder to acquire, higher-cost cards should be more powerful to reflect their rarity.
- **Pokémon has a unique power curve due to its evolution mechanics and the cost structure of its cards.** (medium). [Dylan Mayo \(The Pokemon Company\),](#)
 - *For us:* Consider unique mechanics like evolution stages in Pokémon to create a non-linear power curve. This could involve cards that become more powerful over time or require specific conditions to be met.
- **The speaker discusses the unique experience and balance challenges of 1-turn kill decks in Hearthstone.** (medium). [Eric Dodds \(Hearthstone\), 49:02](#)
 - *For us:* The team should be aware of the balance challenges posed by high-risk, high-reward strategies in multiplayer games. While these strategies can be fun, they may feel unfair to opponents. The team should monitor and address these issues to maintain a balanced and enjoyable experience for all players.

Luck & randomness

- **The Delta of Randomness refers to the range between the maximum and minimum impact a random element can have on gameplay, and it is crucial for game designers to balance this to create exciting moments without making the game feel arbitrary.** (high). [Extra Credits, 0:55](#)
 - *For us:* Dark Charterlands should carefully balance the Delta of Randomness for cards with random effects, ensuring they create exciting moments without making the game feel arbitrary. This is especially important for Edicts, which are one-shot cards. Consider the power curve and the impact of random elements on gameplay.
- **Game designers can mitigate the negative effects of high Delta of Randomness by giving players ways to reduce or eliminate the randomness through strategic play.** (high). [Extra Credits, 6:01](#)
 - *For us:* Provide players with strategic options to mitigate or eliminate randomness in Dark Charterlands. This could mean including cards or abilities that allow players to reduce the impact of random elements, especially when they are behind. This helps maintain balance and fairness while keeping the game exciting.
- **The role of luck in games tends to decrease over time as games mature and players seek to emphasize skill over chance.** (high). [Richard Garfield \(Magic\), 12:42](#)
 - *For us:* As Dark Charterlands matures, consider reducing the role of luck to emphasize skill. This could involve tweaking the draft mechanics or adjusting the influence of random events in the game.
- **The role of luck in games evolves as the audience matures.** (high). [Richard Garfield \(Magic\), 24:35](#)
 - *For us:* Plan for the evolution of luck in the game as the player base matures. This could involve gradually reducing the role of luck in the draft and contest phases over time.

- **Balancing luck and skill is crucial in game design.** (high). [Richard Garfield \(Magic\), 26:18](#)
 - *For us:* Balance luck and skill carefully in the design of Dark Charterlands. This could involve adjusting the draft mechanics, the influence of random events, or the hidden actions in the COMMIT phase to ensure that the game remains engaging for both beginners and experienced players.
- **The game's design emphasizes the importance of randomness, both input and output, in creating engaging gameplay.** (medium). [Ben Brode \(Marvel Snap\), 31:29](#)
 - *For us:* Dark Charterlands should incorporate both input and output randomness to create engaging and unpredictable gameplay. This could involve designing cards and mechanics that encourage strategic decision-making based on random events, as well as revealing outcomes that keep players engaged.
- **The randomness in Hearthstone's Arena mode creates unique and memorable stories.** (medium). [Eric Dodds \(Hearthstone\), 39:31](#)
 - *For us:* The draft mechanic in Dark Charterlands can create unique and memorable stories. The team should embrace this randomness to enhance the gameplay experience, similar to Hearthstone's Arena mode.
- **Luck can be introduced into games through various mechanisms.** (medium). [Richard Garfield \(Magic\), 5:42](#)
 - *For us:* Consider how to introduce luck through the draft and hidden actions in the COMMIT phase. This could add variety and unpredictability to the game, but it should be balanced carefully to avoid trivializing strategic decisions.
- **Luck is defined as uncertainty in outcome.** (medium). [Richard Garfield \(Magic\), 9:57](#)
 - *For us:* Be mindful of how players perceive randomness in the game, especially in the draft and contest phases. Ensure that the random elements are clear and that players understand the role of luck in their outcomes.
- **Adding luck to games can increase variety and prevent players from getting stuck in strategic ruts.** (medium). [Richard Garfield \(Magic\), 14:49](#)
 - *For us:* Introduce luck to prevent players from getting stuck in strategic ruts. This could be achieved through the use of random events or hidden actions in the COMMIT and CONTEST phases, encouraging players to explore new strategies.
- **Luck in games can protect players' egos and broaden the audience by making games more accessible to a wider range of players.** (medium). [Richard Garfield \(Magic\), 19:47](#)
 - *For us:* Ensure that the game's luck elements make it accessible to a wide range of players. This could involve balancing the draft mechanics or adjusting the influence of random events to make the game more palatable for beginners.
- **Increasing the number of trials can reduce the impact of luck.** (medium). [Richard Garfield \(Magic\), 27:25](#)
 - *For us:* Consider increasing the number of trials in the game to reduce the impact of luck. This could involve adding more rounds or seasons to the game, allowing players to average out their luck over time.

- **The role of luck in games can significantly impact player immersion and enjoyment.** (medium). [Richard Garfield \(Magic\), 40:11](#)
 - *For us:* Be aware of how luck can impact player immersion and enjoyment. Ensure that the game's luck elements are front-loaded in longer games to maintain player engagement throughout. This could involve adjusting the draft mechanics or the influence of random events in the early phases of the game.
- **A certain degree of randomness is beneficial for maintaining player engagement, especially for smaller audiences.** (medium). [Skaaf Elias, 17:27](#)
 - *For us:* The team should incorporate a certain degree of randomness to maintain player engagement, especially for smaller audiences. This randomness should not diminish the skill required to play the game but should add an element that makes the game more engaging and accessible to a wider range of players.
- **Randomness in games keeps players engaged and maintains interest.** (medium). [Skaaf Elias, 20:22](#)
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that randomness is a key part of the game to keep players engaged. This randomness will provide feedback that keeps players involved and makes the game fun, preventing players from quickly figuring out the best strategies and losing interest.

Turn structure & pacing

- **First move advantage is a significant design challenge in turn-based games, requiring careful balancing to ensure fairness.** (high). [Extra Credits, 0:23](#)
 - *For us:* The team should consider giving the second player some advantage to mitigate the first move advantage. This could be in the form of extra cards, points, or other benefits. Since Dark Charterlands is a developed-resource game, the impact of first move advantage could be significant, so this should be carefully balanced.
- **Hearthstone's design simplified traditional collectible card game mechanics, such as turn phases and resource management, to enhance accessibility and gameplay speed.** (high). [Eric Dodds \(Hearthstone\), 10:46](#)
 - *For us:* Dark Charterlands should focus on a single phase per turn to enhance accessibility and gameplay speed. This approach can add tactical depth by allowing players to act in any order during their turn, similar to Hearthstone's design.
- **Race for the Galaxy features simultaneous action selection and multiple victory conditions, creating strategic depth.** (high). [Tom Lehmann, 3:17](#)
 - *For us:* Consider implementing simultaneous action selection to ensure each round is dynamic and encourages strategic planning. This could be integrated into the COMMIT phase where players secretly place units. Additionally, explore multiple victory conditions to create strategic tension, such as hidden objectives that players can pursue alongside the main goal of becoming the Regent.

- **The design of Race for the Galaxy was influenced by the speaker's experience with Puerto Rico and the need to eliminate 'left-right binding' in game mechanics.** (high).

[Tom Lehmann, 18:35](#)

- *For us:* Avoid 'left-right binding' by ensuring that players' actions do not overly constrain the next player's options. The simultaneous action selection in the COMMIT phase can help mitigate this issue, giving players more agency and allowing the game to evolve in many directions.

Card & mechanic design

- **Don't confuse interesting with fun in game design.** (high). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 14:37](#)

- *For us:* The team should prioritize emotional stimulation over intellectual stimulation. Mechanics that are fun to play with should be favored over those that are merely interesting but not engaging.

- **Be more afraid of boring players than challenging them.** (high). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 49:02](#)

- *For us:* The team should be more afraid of boring players than challenging them. Ensuring that Dark Charterlands is engaging and exciting is more important than making it overly complex or difficult.

- **The game underwent significant changes, including a pivot from the Infinity Stones theme and the simplification of mechanics.** (high). [Ben Brode \(Marvel Snap\), 43:29](#)

- *For us:* The team should be prepared to simplify mechanics and cut unnecessary features to maintain a streamlined core loop. This could involve focusing on the essential elements of the game and removing any complexities that do not add significant value.

- **The video suggests starting with the most constrained cards when designing a TCG set to avoid painting oneself into a corner.** (high). [Rempton Games, 9:40](#)

- *For us:* The team should start designing the most constrained cards first, such as those with unique abilities or specific roles in the game. This approach will help avoid ending up with no good solutions for the remaining cards and ensure that the set remains balanced and cohesive. The team should also consider the additional limitations that each designed card adds to the design space for the more open-ended designs.

- **Resonance is important in game design, as players come with pre-existing emotional responses.** (medium). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 8:27](#)

- *For us:* The team should leverage players' pre-existing emotional responses to create a richer game experience. For instance, incorporating familiar fantasy tropes or themes that players already have emotional responses to can enhance engagement.

- **Understand the emotion your game is trying to evoke.** (medium). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 17:38](#)

- *For us:* The team should design Dark Charterlands to evoke specific emotional responses, such as excitement, tension, or triumph, and ensure that the game mechanics support these emotions.

- **Allow players to make the game personal by providing choices.** (medium). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 21:27](#)
 - *For us:* The team should provide players with meaningful choices to make the game feel personal. For example, allowing players to customize their decks or strategies can enhance their sense of ownership and investment.
- **The details are where players fall in love with your game.** (medium). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 25:37](#)
 - *For us:* The team should pay attention to the details in Dark Charterlands, as these can be the elements that players bond with. Unique and memorable details can make the game more engaging and enjoyable.
- **The details in game design are crucial because they allow players to bond with the game.** (medium). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 25:55](#)
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that even small details in Dark Charterlands are well-designed, as these can be very important to a subset of players. These details can make a player fall in love with the game.
- **Allow players to have a sense of ownership through customization.** (medium). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 28:42](#)
 - *For us:* The team should allow players to have a sense of ownership through customization. For example, allowing players to customize their decks or strategies can enhance their sense of ownership and investment in the game.
- **Leave room for players to explore and discover.** (medium). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 32:51](#)
 - *For us:* The team should leave room for players to explore and discover in Dark Charterlands. This discovery process increases player investment and enjoyment.
- **Evoking strong responses is more important than minimizing negative ones.** (medium). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 34:23](#)
 - *For us:* The team should aim to evoke strong responses in players, understanding that some players may love certain aspects while others may hate them. The goal is to create a game that evokes strong emotions, whether positive or negative.
- **Restrictions can foster creativity in game design.** (medium). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 54:56](#)
 - *For us:* The team should consider imposing restrictions in Dark Charterlands to foster creativity. Restrictions can force designers to think in new ways, leading to innovative ideas and solutions.
- **The game's design was influenced by various board and card games, including Backgammon, Clash Royale, and Lord of the Rings: The Confrontation.** (medium). [Ben Brode \(Marvel Snap\), 25:57](#)
 - *For us:* Incorporating simultaneous reveals, as inspired by Lord of the Rings: The Confrontation, could enhance the strategic depth and excitement of the CONTEST phase in Dark Charterlands. This mechanic could make the reveal more engaging and reduce downtime.

- **The game's core mechanics involve guardians protecting denisins to score points.** (medium). [Ten Hundred, 1:58](#)
 - *For us:* Ensure that the core loop of Muster, Commit, Contest, Edicts, and Reckoning is engaging and maintains player interest throughout the 20-40 minute game length. Consider how the scoring of denisins in the video can inform how players accumulate Renown in Dark Charterlands.
- **The emergence of roguelike deck-building games and their impact on the genre.** (medium). [Extra Credits, 6:32](#)
 - *For us:* The team should consider the onboarding experience for new players, as roguelike deck-building games can be complex. Ensure that Dark Charterlands has a clear and engaging tutorial to help new players understand the core loop and mechanics.
- **The UI design in Hearthstone significantly influenced the game's design and mechanics, with the two aspects informing each other throughout development.** (medium). [Hearthstone team, 28:32](#)
 - *For us:* Ensure that the design of the physical cards and other UI elements informs the game mechanics and vice versa. This iterative process can help create a more cohesive and engaging game experience.
- **Hearthstone's design emphasizes emotional responses over mechanical balance.** (medium). [Eric Dodds \(Hearthstone\), 41:08](#)
 - *For us:* The team should consider the emotional impact of randomness in Dark Charterlands. While some randomness can create unique stories, it's important to balance it to avoid negative emotional responses from players.
- **The design of cards should appeal to various player types, including Spike, Johnny, and Timmy players.** (medium). [Tom Lehmann, 47:58](#)
 - *For us:* Design cards and abilities that appeal to different player types. Ensure that the game has multiple winning strategies to keep it interesting and balanced. This can be achieved by offering a variety of draft archetypes and abilities that cater to different playstyles.

Onboarding & complexity

- **Fighting against human nature is a losing battle in game design.** (high). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\),](#)
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that the rules and mechanics of Dark Charterlands align with players' natural instincts and expectations. For example, if players intuitively understand that they should be able to attack with certain units, the rules should accommodate this.
- **Piggybacking on pre-existing knowledge can help teach game mechanics more easily.** (high). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 10:50](#)
 - *For us:* The team should use familiar concepts to help teach game mechanics more easily. For example, if a mechanic is similar to something players already understand, it will be easier for them to grasp.

- **The design team focused on creating a game with low complexity and high depth, using the 'snap' mechanic to add strategic depth without increasing the game's complexity.** (high). [Ben Brode \(Marvel Snap\), 14:36](#)
 - *For us:* Dark Charterlands should strive for low complexity and high depth, using its unique mechanics to add strategic depth without overwhelming new players. This could involve simplifying the initial learning curve and gradually introducing more complex strategies.
- **The game's design philosophy focuses on minimizing complexity and maximizing player satisfaction.** (high). [Ben Brode \(Marvel Snap\), 50:32](#)
 - *For us:* The team should focus on keeping the game simple and intuitive, even as new mechanics and cards are added. This could involve gradually introducing complexity and ensuring that new additions are easy to understand for current players.
- **The concept of a 'seed' is crucial for guiding the design direction of a game's user interface.** (high). [Hearthstone team, 0:58](#)
 - *For us:* The team should identify a clear 'seed' or guiding muse for Dark Charterlands' design to ensure a cohesive and immersive experience. This seed should inform all aspects of the game, from the physical cards to the overall theme and mechanics.
- **Embracing physicality in UI design makes the game feel more valuable and immersive.** (high). [Hearthstone team, 7:53](#)
 - *For us:* Emphasize the physicality of the cards and the overall game experience to make Dark Charterlands feel more valuable and immersive. This can be achieved through tactile and visual design elements that enhance the player's connection to the game world.
- **The physical UI design of Hearthstone enhances the player experience by making the game feel cohesive and immersive.** (high). [Hearthstone team, 10:07](#)
 - *For us:* Focus on creating a cohesive and immersive experience through physical UI elements, such as the design of the cards and the overall aesthetic of the game. This can enhance the player's sense of being part of the game world.
- **The primary goal in designing Hearthstone was to make collectible card games more accessible to a broader audience by simplifying complex mechanics.** (high). [Eric Dodds \(Hearthstone\), 10:00](#)
 - *For us:* The team should simplify the core mechanics of Dark Charterlands to make it accessible to new players. This includes streamlining the turn phases and resource management, ensuring that players can start playing quickly without being overwhelmed by complexity.
- **The game design prioritizes immediate fun for new players, ensuring a smooth learning curve.** (high). [Eric Dodds \(Hearthstone\),](#)
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that Dark Charterlands is immediately fun for new players. This involves keeping instructions concise and using visual cues to help players understand the game quickly, allowing them to learn more as they play.

- **The game design prioritized using familiar mechanics and terminology to ensure players understand the game without extensive explanation.** (high). [Eric Dodds \(Hearthstone\)](#), 31:25
 - *For us:* Dark Charterlands should use familiar mechanics and terminology to make the game intuitive. This includes using common terms for actions and traits, reducing the need for extensive tutorials and helping players grasp the game's mechanics more quickly.
- **The time between deciding to play and actually having fun should be minimized.** (high). [Ben Brode](#), 6:45
 - *For us:* The team should focus on streamlining the initial setup and draft process to minimize the time between deciding to play and actually having fun. This includes ensuring that the physical components are easy to handle and that the rules are quickly understandable.
- **Design components for the intended audience, not for everyone.** (medium). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\)](#), 46:07
 - *For us:* The team should design Dark Charterlands with specific player types in mind, understanding that different players have different emotional needs and motivations. This ensures that each component is maximized for its intended audience.
- **The design process for Hearthstone involved exploring various prototypes and concepts before settling on the final UI.** (medium). [Hearthstone team](#), 1:20
 - *For us:* Encourage an iterative design process with multiple prototypes to refine the vision for Dark Charterlands. This approach can help the team identify the most engaging and cohesive design elements for the game.
- **The UI design team at Hearthstone is given equal importance to game design, ensuring a cohesive and immersive player experience.** (medium). [Hearthstone team](#), 17:29
 - *For us:* Ensure that the design of the physical cards and other UI elements is given equal importance to the game mechanics. This collaborative approach can help create a more immersive and cohesive player experience.
- **The development of Hearthstone's UI involved a collaborative and iterative process, with input from various team members including designers, programmers, and artists.** (medium). [Hearthstone team](#),
 - *For us:* Foster a collaborative and iterative design process involving all relevant team members, including designers, artists, and programmers. This approach can help ensure that the physical cards and other UI elements are both functional and visually appealing.

Community, leagues & house rules

- **Educating players can mitigate the Dunning-Kruger effect, reducing misinformed criticism and improving community sentiment.** (medium). [Ben Brode](#), 24:37
 - *For us:* The team should consider educating players about the design principles behind Community Charters and how to effectively use them. This can help reduce misinformed criticism and improve community sentiment around house rules.

- **Developers should engage directly with the community to build trust and manage expectations.** (medium). [Ben Brode, 29:08](#)
 - *For us:* The team should engage directly with the community to build trust and manage expectations around Community Charters. This includes being visible in community discussions and responding quickly to feedback.
- **Limiting the number of game formats can help maintain a robust player base.** (medium). [Skaff Elias,](#)
 - *For us:* The team should consider limiting the number of game formats to maintain a robust player base. Too many formats can dilute the player base, making it difficult to sustain interest and social currency in any single format, which is crucial for a multiplayer free-for-all game.
- **Organized play, such as tournaments and leagues, is a powerful tool in game design and marketing.** (medium). [Skaff Elias, 41:02](#)
 - *For us:* The team should consider organized play as a powerful tool in game design and marketing. This can help patch the game by changing the format, which in turn affects how people play the game, and is crucial for a game with Community Charters and store League Kits.

Playtesting & metrics

- **The speaker is seeking input from the audience on various aspects of the game.** (high). [Ten Hundred,](#)
 - *For us:* Engage with the community for feedback on character names, game mechanics, and other design aspects. Use polls and other interactive methods to gather input, similar to how the speaker is seeking audience suggestions.
- **The development of Slay the Spire involved extensive iterative design and playtesting, inspired by Picasso's methodical approach to art.** (high). [Anthony Giovannetti \(Mega Crit\), 2:21](#)
 - *For us:* The team should prioritize extensive playtesting and iterative design, ensuring that every card and element in Dark Charterlands is well-tested and balanced. This involves constant refinement based on playtest feedback to avoid overpowered effects.
- **The development team used specific tools to amplify their playtesting efforts, including an internal play tester Slack and an in-house metric server.** (high). [Anthony Giovannetti \(Mega Crit\), 7:30](#)
 - *For us:* The team should implement tools for efficient playtesting and feedback collection, such as a dedicated communication channel for playtesters and a metric server to gather anonymous data. This will help in making informed decisions about game balance.
- **The developers adopted an iterative approach to game development, constantly changing and improving the game based on player feedback.** (high). [Anthony Giovannetti \(Mega Crit\), 20:16](#)
 - *For us:* The team should adopt an iterative approach to game development, constantly refining Dark Charterlands based on player feedback. This includes being open to swift changes and improvements, such as reworking cards or mechanics based on playtest results.

- **The design process for a TCG set is iterative and involves continuous playtesting to refine and balance the cards.** (high). [Rempton Games, 10:26](#)
 - *For us:* The team should engage in continuous playtesting to refine and balance the cards in Dark Charterlands. Early playtests should focus on ensuring major themes are fun and clear. As the set develops, playtests should shift to balancing draft archetypes and subthemes, and fine-tuning power levels. The design process should be cyclical, involving creating cards, playtesting, making changes, and repeating.
- **Audience feedback is valuable for identifying problems but not necessarily for solving them.** (medium). [Mark Rosewater \(Magic\), 57:38](#)
 - *For us:* The team should use audience feedback to identify problems in Dark Charterlands but should not rely on the audience for solutions. Designers should use their expertise to solve these problems.
- **The development process involved rapid prototyping and iterative testing, with a small team initially.** (medium). [Ben Brode \(Marvel Snap\),](#)
 - *For us:* The team should consider rapid prototyping and iterative testing to quickly refine mechanics and ensure a smooth gameplay experience. This approach could help identify and address issues early in the development process.
- **The speaker emphasizes the importance of using both active and passive playtesting methods to gather valuable data for game development.** (medium). [Anthony Giovannetti \(Mega Crit\), 10:15](#)
 - *For us:* The team should combine active and passive playtesting methods to gather comprehensive data. This includes both direct feedback from playtesters and anonymous data collection to ensure a well-rounded understanding of the game's balance and player experience.
- **The early access model allowed for significant improvements in metric collection and player feedback, leading to a more balanced and complete game.** (medium). [Anthony Giovannetti \(Mega Crit\), 12:30](#)
 - *For us:* Consider an early access model or beta testing phase to gather a larger player base and more valuable metric data. This can lead to a more balanced and complete game, especially if the team can maintain a consistent update schedule.
- **The game's design was heavily influenced by player feedback and metric data, which were crucial in shaping the game's features and balancing.** (medium). [Anthony Giovannetti \(Mega Crit\), 20:25](#)
 - *For us:* Utilize various channels to gather player feedback, including Discord, social media, and in-person events. This direct connection to the player base will help in understanding what features are desired and making informed decisions about the game's design and balance.

Business & distribution

- **The creation and impact of Magic: The Gathering on the gaming industry.** (high). [Extra Credits, 3:21](#)
 - *For us:* The team should study Magic: The Gathering's costing and balance, as it has been refined over decades. Consider how the influence costing in Dark Charterlands compares to Magic's mana costing, and ensure that the game's balance is robust enough to support a wide variety of strategies and archetypes.
- **Distributed object games, which include CCGs, are characterized by hundreds of semi-individually purchasable objects that change gameplay over time.** (high). [Skaff Elias, 4:49](#)
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that the costing of cards and the value they provide are balanced and clear to players. This is crucial for maintaining player engagement and satisfaction, especially since Dark Charterlands is a high-depth strategy game.
- **The value of purchases in a game should increase logarithmically to ensure new players can catch up and to maintain engagement for all players.** (high). [Skaff Elias, 13:51](#)
 - *For us:* The team should design the game so that the value of purchases increases logarithmically rather than linearly. This approach will help new players catch up and maintain engagement for all players, which is essential for a game with a high depth of strategy and a multiplayer free-for-all format.
- **Clarity in the benefits of purchases is crucial for maintaining player engagement and satisfaction.** (high). [Skaff Elias, 12:27](#)
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that the benefits of purchasing cards are clear to players. This clarity is essential for maintaining player engagement and satisfaction, especially in a game where players invest significant time and resources.
- **The speaker highlights the interconnected nature of game design and business decisions in digital games, particularly how changes in rarity and power of objects can significantly impact the game's economy.** (high). [Skaff Elias,](#)
 - *For us:* The team should be aware that changes in the rarity or power of cards can significantly impact the game's economy. This understanding is crucial for maintaining a balanced game and ensuring that players see the value in their purchases over time.
- **The design of Marvel Snap was influenced by Brode's experience working on Hearthstone, where he learned valuable lessons about game design and player engagement.** (medium). [Ben Brode \(Marvel Snap\), 0:32](#)
 - *For us:* The team should aim to create a game that is easy to learn but has high strategic depth, similar to how Brode's experience with Hearthstone influenced Marvel Snap. This means focusing on a simple core loop and gradually introducing more complex strategies.
- **Having a clear and shared vision is crucial for game development teams.** (medium). [Ben Brode,](#)
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that all members involved in creating Community Charters share a clear vision of what these rules aim to achieve. Regular check-ins can help maintain alignment among the team.

- **Understanding your customer base and the implications of price changes is crucial for game design.** (medium). [Skaff Elias, 40:10](#)
 - *For us:* The team should understand their customer base and the implications of price changes. This understanding is crucial for designing a game that appeals to the target audience and maintains player engagement over time.
- **The speaker emphasizes the importance of cross-functional collaboration within an organization to create a cohesive and valuable product for customers.** (medium). [Skaff Elias, 49:40](#)
 - *For us:* The team should ensure cross-functional collaboration within the organization to create a cohesive and valuable product for customers. This is crucial for a game with a high depth of strategy and a complex design, as it ensures that all aspects of the game are well-integrated and valuable to players.

Per video

Magic: the Gathering: 20 Years, 20 Lessons Learned (GDC 2016)

Mark Rosewater (Magic) · 1,083,891 views

Summary: Mark Rosewater, the head designer for Magic: The Gathering, shares 20 lessons from his 20-year career in game design, emphasizing the importance of understanding human nature, aesthetics, and emotional resonance. He highlights the significance of details, customization, and player motivations, using examples from Magic: The Gathering, including the Ravnica set. Rosewater also discusses the value of taking risks, the impact of small changes, and the importance of audience feedback in game design.

Lesson for us: The most important lesson from this video is that understanding human nature, aesthetics, and emotional resonance is crucial for creating a compelling and engaging game experience, and that small changes and details can have a significant impact on gameplay.

- **Fighting against human nature is a losing battle in game design.** (*Onboarding & complexity, high*)
 - Rosewater emphasizes that game designers should not try to change players to match the game, but rather change the game to match the players. He uses the example of the 'suspend' mechanic in Magic: The Gathering, where players were initially confused about attacking with suspended creatures. The solution was to change the rules to allow attacking, aligning with human nature.
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that the rules and mechanics of Dark Charterlands align with players' natural instincts and expectations. For example, if players intuitively understand that they should be able to attack with certain units, the rules should accommodate this.

- **8:27 Resonance is important in game design, as players come with pre-existing emotional responses.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - Rosewater discusses the concept of resonance, where game designers can build upon players' pre-existing emotional responses to create a richer game experience. He uses the example of zombies in Magic: The Gathering, which players already had emotional responses to from pop culture.
 - *For us:* The team should leverage players' pre-existing emotional responses to create a richer game experience. For instance, incorporating familiar fantasy tropes or themes that players already have emotional responses to can enhance engagement.
- **10:50 Piggybacking on pre-existing knowledge can help teach game mechanics more easily.** (*Onboarding & complexity, high*)
 - Rosewater introduces the concept of 'piggybacking,' where pre-existing knowledge is used to front-load game information and make learning easier. He cites the example of the 'Flying' mechanic in Magic: The Gathering, which is easy to teach because it matches players' expectations of what flying means.
 - *For us:* The team should use familiar concepts to help teach game mechanics more easily. For example, if a mechanic is similar to something players already understand, it will be easier for them to grasp.
- **14:37 Don't confuse interesting with fun in game design.** (*Card & mechanic design, high*)
 - Rosewater distinguishes between intellectual stimulation (interesting) and emotional stimulation (fun), and argues that games should prioritize the latter. He uses the example of the 'Patrol Hound' card in Magic: The Gathering, which was interesting but not fun to play with.
 - *For us:* The team should prioritize emotional stimulation over intellectual stimulation. Mechanics that are fun to play with should be favored over those that are merely interesting but not engaging.
- **17:38 Understand the emotion your game is trying to evoke.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - Rosewater emphasizes the importance of understanding the emotional response players are trying to experience, and designing the game accordingly. He uses the example of the Gothic horror set in Magic: The Gathering, which was designed to evoke fear and suspense.
 - *For us:* The team should design Dark Charterlands to evoke specific emotional responses, such as excitement, tension, or triumph, and ensure that the game mechanics support these emotions.
- **21:27 Allow players to make the game personal by providing choices.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - Rosewater discusses the importance of giving players choices to make the game feel personal to them. He cites the example of full art lands in Magic: The Gathering, which players attached to and cared about.
 - *For us:* The team should provide players with meaningful choices to make the game feel personal. For example, allowing players to customize their decks or strategies can enhance their sense of ownership and investment.

- **25:37 The details are where players fall in love with your game.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - Rosewater highlights the importance of details in game design, as players bond with specific elements of the game. He uses the example of the 'Fibble' character in Magic: The Gathering, which players took to and created various fan content around.
 - *For us:* The team should pay attention to the details in Dark Charterlands, as these can be the elements that players bond with. Unique and memorable details can make the game more engaging and enjoyable.
- **25:55 The details in game design are crucial because they allow players to bond with the game.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - The speaker emphasizes that even small, seemingly insignificant details can be very important to a subset of players. These details can make a player fall in love with the game. The speaker gives the example of a bear punching a popular character, highlighting that details matter because individuals want to find something unique in the game that they can claim as their own.
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that even small details in Dark Charterlands are well-designed, as these can be very important to a subset of players. These details can make a player fall in love with the game.
- **28:42 Allow players to have a sense of ownership through customization.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - The speaker discusses the importance of customization in game design, using the example of Magic: The Gathering. Players can choose their own decks and customize them with specific cards, frames, and art. This customization makes the deck an extension of the player's identity, enhancing their sense of ownership and investment in the game.
 - *For us:* The team should allow players to have a sense of ownership through customization. For example, allowing players to customize their decks or strategies can enhance their sense of ownership and investment in the game.
- **32:51 Leave room for players to explore and discover.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - The speaker compares game design to pitching a story in Hollywood, where the goal is to get the audience to ask questions and be invested. In game design, this means not always showing players what they should see, but letting them discover things on their own. This discovery process increases player investment and enjoyment.
 - *For us:* The team should leave room for players to explore and discover in Dark Charterlands. This discovery process increases player investment and enjoyment.

- **34:23 Evoking strong responses is more important than minimizing negative ones.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - The speaker uses the metaphor of a blind date to illustrate that players need to love something about the game, even if they hate other parts. The goal is to evoke strong responses, as things that evoke strong responses will often evoke strong responses in many directions. The speaker suggests that it's almost impossible to make players love something without making other players hate it.
 - *For us:* The team should aim to evoke strong responses in players, understanding that some players may love certain aspects while others may hate them. The goal is to create a game that evokes strong emotions, whether positive or negative.
- **46:07 Design components for the intended audience, not for everyone.** (*Onboarding & complexity, medium*)
 - The speaker introduces the concept of player psychographics, categorizing players into Timmy, Johnny, and Spike. Each type of player has different emotional needs and motivations. The speaker advises designing components for the specific audience they are intended for, rather than trying to please everyone. This ensures that each component is maximized for its intended audience.
 - *For us:* The team should design Dark Charterlands with specific player types in mind, understanding that different players have different emotional needs and motivations. This ensures that each component is maximized for its intended audience.
- **49:02 Be more afraid of boring players than challenging them.** (*Card & mechanic design, high*)
 - The speaker shares their experience with introducing split cards in Magic: The Gathering, which were initially met with resistance but ultimately loved by players. The speaker advises that challenging players is less risky than boring them, as players will forgive attempts at grandeur but resent being bored.
 - *For us:* The team should be more afraid of boring players than challenging them. Ensuring that Dark Charterlands is engaging and exciting is more important than making it overly complex or difficult.
- **53:05 Small changes can have a significant impact on game design.** (*Draft & set structure, high*)
 - The speaker highlights how a minor change in the design philosophy of Ravnica, from encouraging players to use as many colors as possible to using as few as possible, led to a radically different and highly successful game set. This principle is illustrated with the metaphor of adding too many peas to a dish, which can muddy the message and create unnecessary complexity.
 - *For us:* The team should be aware that small changes in Dark Charterlands can have a significant impact on the game. Even minor adjustments to mechanics or rules can lead to radically different gameplay experiences.

- **54:56 Restrictions can foster creativity in game design.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - The speaker argues that having restrictions can actually enhance creativity. The brain tends to use familiar neural pathways to solve problems, leading to repetitive solutions. By imposing restrictions, designers are forced to think in new ways, leading to innovative ideas and solutions. The speaker shares an example of writing an article on a unique topic combination that resulted from self-imposed restrictions.
 - *For us:* The team should consider imposing restrictions in Dark Charterlands to foster creativity. Restrictions can force designers to think in new ways, leading to innovative ideas and solutions.
- **57:38 Audience feedback is valuable for identifying problems but not necessarily for solving them.** (*Playtesting & metrics, medium*)
 - The speaker emphasizes that while the audience is excellent at recognizing issues in a game, they are not as equipped to solve these problems. Designers should use audience feedback to identify problems but should not rely on the audience for solutions, as they lack the necessary tools and knowledge.
 - *For us:* The team should use audience feedback to identify problems in Dark Charterlands but should not rely on the audience for solutions. Designers should use their expertise to solve these problems.

Power Creep in Hearthstone

Extra Credits · 823,710 views

Summary: The video discusses the concept of power creep in games, using Hearthstone as an example. It explains how power creep can occur unintentionally due to the complexity of game design, and how it can affect the balance and longevity of a game. The speaker also highlights the importance of understanding the power curve and how certain cards can inadvertently set a new baseline for future card design.

Lesson for us: The team should prioritize understanding and maintaining a healthy power curve to prevent unintentional power creep, which could disrupt the game's balance and longevity.

- **1:04 Power creep in games can occur unintentionally due to the complexity of game design, particularly in collectible card games like Hearthstone.** (*Costing & balance, high*)
 - The speaker explains that power creep can happen accidentally as designers work on increasingly complex sets of interlocking pieces, such as cards in a collectible card game. This type of power creep is more insidious because it is not immediately obvious and can lead to long-term issues with game balance. The speaker uses Hearthstone as an example, discussing how certain cards like Piloted Shredder can set a new baseline for future card design, forcing designers to create increasingly powerful cards to keep up. This unintentional power creep can delete all the design space below the new baseline, making previously playable cards obsolete.
 - *For us:* The team should be vigilant about the power level of new cards, especially those with unique abilities, to avoid setting a new baseline that could lead to power creep. They should regularly review the power curve of the game and ensure that new cards fit within the established design space. This is particularly important given the game's high-depth strategy expectation and the use of a costing formula based on MetaZoo's rate.
- **1:32 Understanding the power curve is crucial for identifying and mitigating power creep in games.** (*Costing & balance, high*)
 - The speaker defines the power curve as the graph created by plotting the power and cost of each card in a game. Cards that spike too high above this curve risk breaking the game, while those that spike too low risk being unplayable. The speaker uses examples from Hearthstone to illustrate how cards like Piloted Shredder can set a new baseline for future card design, impacting the overall power level of the game. By understanding the power curve, designers can better identify when power creep is occurring and take steps to mitigate it.
 - *For us:* The team should create and maintain a power curve for Dark Charterlands, plotting the Influence (power) and cost of each card. This will help identify cards that spike too high or too low, allowing for better balance and mitigation of power creep. Regularly updating this curve with new releases will be crucial.

First Move Advantage - How to Balance Turn-Based Games

Extra Credits · 778,958 views

Summary: The video discusses the concept of 'First Move Advantage' in turn-based games, highlighting the challenges designers face in balancing this advantage. It explores different types of turn-based games and provides strategies for mitigating the first move advantage, emphasizing the importance of continuous monitoring and adjustment.

Lesson for us: The team should be aware of the first move advantage and implement mechanics to mitigate it, especially since Dark Charterlands is a developed-resource game.

- **0:23 First move advantage is a significant design challenge in turn-based games, requiring careful balancing to ensure fairness.** (*Turn structure & pacing, high*)
 - The video explains that in many turn-based games, the player who goes first has a significant advantage. Designers must implement mechanics to compensate for this, such as giving the second player extra cards or points. The example of Go is used to illustrate how the handicap for the starting player has been adjusted over time, but it's never been quite enough to fully balance the game. In Hearthstone, the second player gets multiple benefits, which some professional players find over-balanced. The video also notes that the impact of first move advantage is greater in developed-resource games, where players build up resources over time, compared to static-resource games where all pieces are available from the start.
 - *For us:* The team should consider giving the second player some advantage to mitigate the first move advantage. This could be in the form of extra cards, points, or other benefits. Since Dark Charterlands is a developed-resource game, the impact of first move advantage could be significant, so this should be carefully balanced.

The Delta of Randomness - Can You Balance for RNG?

Extra Credits · 539,644 views

Summary: The video discusses the concept of the 'Delta of Randomness' in games, using Hearthstone as a primary example. It explores how random elements can affect gameplay, player experience, and design decisions, emphasizing the importance of balancing randomness to create exciting moments without making the game feel arbitrary.

Lesson for us: The team should focus on balancing the Delta of Randomness to ensure that exciting moments in Dark Charterlands are created without making the game feel arbitrary, and provide strategic options to mitigate or eliminate randomness.

- **0:55 The Delta of Randomness refers to the range between the maximum and minimum impact a random element can have on gameplay, and it is crucial for game designers to balance this to create exciting moments without making the game feel arbitrary.** (*Luck & randomness, high*)
 - The Delta of Randomness is not just the difference between the maximum and minimum impact of a random element, but rather the distance from the power curve. A card with a high Delta of Randomness can have a significant impact on the game, but it can also make the game feel arbitrary if the random element is too swingy. Designers must balance this Delta to ensure that random elements create exciting moments without overshadowing the strategic aspects of the game. For example, a card like Flame Juggler has a low Delta of Randomness, making it playable in most situations and creating intense moments without being game-breaking.
 - *For us:* Dark Charterlands should carefully balance the Delta of Randomness for cards with random effects, ensuring they create exciting moments without making the game feel arbitrary. This is especially important for Edicts, which are one-shot cards. Consider the power curve and the impact of random elements on gameplay.

- **6:01 Game designers can mitigate the negative effects of high Delta of Randomness by giving players ways to reduce or eliminate the randomness through strategic play.**

(Luck & randomness, high)

- One strategy to manage high Delta of Randomness is to provide players with options to reduce or eliminate the random element. For instance, the card Bomb Lobber allows players to eliminate the randomness by reducing the opponent's board to one minion before playing it. This design ensures that the random element is only used when the player is behind, helping them catch up without giving an extra bonus to players who are already ahead. This approach maintains the excitement of randomness while keeping the game balanced and fair.
- *For us:* Provide players with strategic options to mitigate or eliminate randomness in Dark Charterlands. This could mean including cards or abilities that allow players to reduce the impact of random elements, especially when they are behind. This helps maintain balance and fairness while keeping the game exciting.

Collectible Games III: What Makes a Good TCG or CCG?

Extra Credits · 376,192 views

Summary: The video discusses the benefits and depth of collectible card games (CCGs) and trading card games (TCGs), highlighting how they evolve with new cards, manage information complexity, and offer unique gameplay experiences. The speaker emphasizes that while these games can be dangerous if used purely for monetization, they also provide rich and dynamic gameplay experiences when designed well.

Lesson for us: The team should focus on designing Dark Charterlands to be a dynamic and evolving game that encourages players to explore different strategies and adapt to new cards, ensuring a rich and engaging gameplay experience.

- **0:33 Collectible card games (CCGs) and trading card games (TCGs) offer dynamic and evolving gameplay experiences as players acquire new cards.** *(Draft & set structure, high)*
 - The speaker explains that collectible games naturally change as players acquire more cards, encouraging them to rethink strategies and integrate new elements. This dynamic nature means players are not stuck with a single play style and are encouraged to explore different tactics. The game continuously presents new puzzles to solve by asking players to make the most effective deck possible. This is more compelling than games where players quickly settle into a strategy or find limited optimal ways to play. The optimal deck for any given player changes over time, making the game more dynamic and personalized.
 - *For us:* The team should design Dark Charterlands to encourage players to explore different tactics and strategies, ensuring that the game remains dynamic and engaging over time. This can be achieved by regularly introducing new cards and mechanics that force players to adapt their strategies. The game should also provide a variety of playstyles and deck-building options to keep players engaged and motivated to collect new cards.

Designing MARVEL SNAP (GDC 2023)

Ben Brode (Marvel Snap) · 262,536 views

Summary: The video features Ben Brode, Chief Development Officer at Second Dinner, discussing the development of Marvel Snap, a mobile-first digital collectible card game. He delves into the game's unique mechanics, the iterative design process, and the influence of his past experience with Hearthstone. Additionally, the video covers the game's development challenges, the collaboration with Marvel, and the importance of maintaining player satisfaction.

Lesson for us: The most important lesson from this video is the importance of balancing complexity and depth in game design, ensuring that the game is accessible to new players while offering strategic depth for experienced players.

- **The development process involved rapid prototyping and iterative testing, with a small team initially.** (*Playtesting & metrics, medium*)
 - The speaker highlights the importance of having a small team during the early stages of development. This allowed for quick pivots and experimentation. The initial prototype was created in just two days, and the team continued to iterate and test different mechanics. The small team size facilitated rapid decision-making and flexibility.
 - *For us:* The team should consider rapid prototyping and iterative testing to quickly refine mechanics and ensure a smooth gameplay experience. This approach could help identify and address issues early in the development process.
- **0:32 The design of Marvel Snap was influenced by Brode's experience working on Hearthstone, where he learned valuable lessons about game design and player engagement.** (*Business & distribution, medium*)
 - Brode spent 15 years at Blizzard, working on games like World of Warcraft, Diablo 2, and Hearthstone. His experience on Hearthstone, particularly the lessons learned from its design and player feedback, significantly influenced the development of Marvel Snap. He emphasizes the importance of gathering ingredients from existing games and combining them in new ways, rather than inventing entirely new ingredients.
 - *For us:* The team should aim to create a game that is easy to learn but has high strategic depth, similar to how Brode's experience with Hearthstone influenced Marvel Snap. This means focusing on a simple core loop and gradually introducing more complex strategies.
- **14:36 The design team focused on creating a game with low complexity and high depth, using the 'snap' mechanic to add strategic depth without increasing the game's complexity.** (*Onboarding & complexity, high*)
 - The design team aimed to create a game with low complexity and high depth. They used the 'snap' mechanic to add strategic depth without increasing the game's complexity. Brode discusses the relationship between complexity and depth in games, and how the 'snap' mechanic allows for a game that is simple to learn but has a lot of strategic depth.
 - *For us:* Dark Characterlands should strive for low complexity and high depth, using its unique mechanics to add strategic depth without overwhelming new players. This could involve simplifying the initial learning curve and gradually introducing more complex strategies.

- **25:57 The game's design was influenced by various board and card games, including Backgammon, Clash Royale, and Lord of the Rings: The Confrontation.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - The speaker mentions several games that inspired the design of Marvel Snap. These include Backgammon for the doubling cube mechanic, Clash Royale for the five-minute mobile-friendly experience, and Lord of the Rings: The Confrontation for simultaneous reveals. Other influences include physical board and card games, which provided the foundation for the game's mechanics.
 - *For us:* Incorporating simultaneous reveals, as inspired by Lord of the Rings: The Confrontation, could enhance the strategic depth and excitement of the CONTEST phase in Dark Charterlands. This mechanic could make the reveal more engaging and reduce downtime.
- **31:29 The game's design emphasizes the importance of randomness, both input and output, in creating engaging gameplay.** (*Luck & randomness, medium*)
 - The speaker discusses the role of randomness in games, distinguishing between input randomness (where players make strategic decisions based on random events) and output randomness (where players make decisions and then see the outcomes). Marvel Snap incorporates both types of randomness to create exciting and unpredictable gameplay.
 - *For us:* Dark Charterlands should incorporate both input and output randomness to create engaging and unpredictable gameplay. This could involve designing cards and mechanics that encourage strategic decision-making based on random events, as well as revealing outcomes that keep players engaged.
- **43:29 The game underwent significant changes, including a pivot from the Infinity Stones theme and the simplification of mechanics.** (*Card & mechanic design, high*)
 - The speaker discusses the challenges faced during the development of Marvel Snap, including the need to simplify the game's mechanics. The team initially struggled with complex systems like leagues and hero collectors but eventually realized that simplification was key. This involved cutting unnecessary features and focusing on a streamlined core loop.
 - *For us:* The team should be prepared to simplify mechanics and cut unnecessary features to maintain a streamlined core loop. This could involve focusing on the essential elements of the game and removing any complexities that do not add significant value.
- **50:32 The game's design philosophy focuses on minimizing complexity and maximizing player satisfaction.** (*Onboarding & complexity, high*)
 - The speaker discusses the importance of keeping the game simple and intuitive, even as it evolves over time. They mention that while there is a fear of running out of design space, they have always found more room to design new cards and mechanics. The goal is to add complexity gradually, ensuring that current players can easily understand new additions.
 - *For us:* The team should focus on keeping the game simple and intuitive, even as new mechanics and cards are added. This could involve gradually introducing complexity and ensuring that new additions are easy to understand for current players.

Designing my own Trading Card Game

Ten Hundred · 238,325 views

Summary: The video documents the initial stages of creating a trading card game, inspired by the speaker's love for games and art. The speaker collaborates with a company called Creo to develop the game, which involves designing unique characters, abilities, and environments. The speaker focuses on the desert biome, creating eight guardians with distinct abilities and appearances, and seeks input from the audience on various aspects of the game's development.

Lesson for us: Engage with the community early and often to gather feedback and shape the game's design, while ensuring the core loop is engaging and the onboarding process is smooth.

- **The speaker is seeking input from the audience on various aspects of the game.**

(Playtesting & metrics, high)

- The speaker encourages the audience to provide feedback and suggestions on the game's development. They mention that the names of the characters and the game itself are not set in stone and are open to suggestions. The speaker also plans to use polls to gather input from the audience on decisions related to the game's design.
- *For us:* Engage with the community for feedback on character names, game mechanics, and other design aspects. Use polls and other interactive methods to gather input, similar to how the speaker is seeking audience suggestions.

- **1:58 The game's core mechanics involve guardians protecting denisins to score points.**

(Card & mechanic design, medium)

- The game's objective is to accumulate 10 points by playing denisin cards, which are protected by guardian cards. Each guardian has a point value that determines how many denisins can be played. The guardians have unique abilities that can change the gameplay dynamics. The game is divided into biomes, each with its own play style and characteristics.
- *For us:* Ensure that the core loop of Muster, Commit, Contest, Edicts, and Reckoning is engaging and maintains player interest throughout the 20-40 minute game length. Consider how the scoring of denisins in the video can inform how players accumulate Renown in Dark Charterlands.

- **3:58 The speaker is focusing on the desert biome for the initial phase of development.**

(Draft & set structure, medium)

- The speaker has narrowed down the biomes to desert, jungle, sky, and ocean for the initial release. They are starting with the desert biome and have created eight guardian characters inspired by desert animals. Each guardian has a unique design, abilities, and a level of power. The speaker is experimenting with different color schemes and styles for the cards.
- *For us:* Start with a limited set of factions and archetypes to ease players into the game. Consider how the desert biome's unique play style can inform the distinct strategies of different factions in Dark Charterlands.

The History of Roguelike Deckbuilders

Extra Credits · 168,918 views

Summary: The video traces the evolution of roguelike deck-building games, from the invention of playing cards to the rise of digital collectible card games (CCGs) and the emergence of roguelike deck builders like Slay the Spire. It highlights key milestones and innovations in the genre, culminating in the introduction of Roguebook, a new game from the creators of Faeria.

Lesson for us: The team should study the evolution of card games and the innovations that have shaped the genre, particularly focusing on costing, balance, and onboarding to ensure Dark Charterlands stands out in the market.

- **3:21 The creation and impact of Magic: The Gathering on the gaming industry.**

(Business & distribution, high)

- Magic: The Gathering, created by Richard Garfield and published by Wizards of the Coast, revolutionized the gaming industry by combining the portability of playing cards with the collectibility of trading cards. It introduced new game types like sealed and draft, which utilized the randomness of card packs to create varied gaming experiences. Magic's success led to the acquisition of Dungeons & Dragons by Wizards of the Coast and has continued to influence the gaming landscape for over 25 years.
- *For us:* The team should study Magic: The Gathering's costing and balance, as it has been refined over decades. Consider how the influence costing in Dark Charterlands compares to Magic's mana costing, and ensure that the game's balance is robust enough to support a wide variety of strategies and archetypes.

- **6:32 The emergence of roguelike deck-building games and their impact on the genre.**

(Card & mechanic design, medium)

- The video highlights the emergence of roguelike deck-building games, starting with Dream Quest in 2014, which married roguelike gameplay with deck-building mechanics. This was followed by the massive success of Slay the Spire, which popularized the genre and inspired many clones. The video also mentions Roguebook, a new game from the creators of Faeria, which aims to innovate further in the roguelike deck-building genre.
- *For us:* The team should consider the onboarding experience for new players, as roguelike deck-building games can be complex. Ensure that Dark Charterlands has a clear and engaging tutorial to help new players understand the core loop and mechanics.

Slay the Spire: Metrics Driven Design and Balance (GDC 2019)

Anthony Giovannetti (Mega Crit) · 163,220 views

Summary: Anthony Giovannetti, co-founder of MegaCrit Games, discusses the development of Slay the Spire, emphasizing the importance of iterative design, playtesting, and player feedback. He details the tools and methods used to gather and analyze player data, the benefits of the early access model, and the challenges of maintaining a weekly update schedule. The video also covers the emotional impact of player feedback and the process of balancing game abilities.

Lesson for us: The most important lesson from this video is the critical role of iterative design, extensive playtesting, and data-driven decision-making in creating a balanced and engaging game.

- **2:21 The development of Slay the Spire involved extensive iterative design and playtesting, inspired by Picasso's methodical approach to art.** (*Playtesting & metrics, high*)
 - Giovannetti compares the development process to Picasso's creation of a famous painting, which involved over 500 preparatory drawings. Similarly, Slay the Spire underwent constant iteration and testing. The speaker emphasizes the importance of playtesting and the challenges faced, particularly as a small indie team. The goal was to ensure that every card and element in the game had a place and was reasonable to take a certain percentage of the time, avoiding overpowered effects that could dominate the game.
 - *For us:* The team should prioritize extensive playtesting and iterative design, ensuring that every card and element in Dark Characterlands is well-tested and balanced. This involves constant refinement based on playtest feedback to avoid overpowered effects.
- **7:30 The development team used specific tools to amplify their playtesting efforts, including an internal play tester Slack and an in-house metric server.** (*Playtesting & metrics, high*)
 - The team utilized an internal Slack channel for play testers to communicate and provide feedback easily. A bot collected all feedback, bug reports, and ideas into one place. Additionally, the team built an in-house metric server that collected anonymous data from players' runs, providing valuable insights into gameplay and balance. This data-driven approach allowed the team to test their assumptions and make informed decisions about the game's balance.
 - *For us:* The team should implement tools for efficient playtesting and feedback collection, such as a dedicated communication channel for playtesters and a metric server to gather anonymous data. This will help in making informed decisions about game balance.
- **10:15 The speaker emphasizes the importance of using both active and passive playtesting methods to gather valuable data for game development.** (*Playtesting & metrics, medium*)
 - The speaker explains that active playtesting, such as attending events or using focus groups, is very time-consuming and does not scale well. In contrast, passive playtesting using a metric server collects data in the background, allowing for more objective decision-making. The speaker suggests that combining these methods can leverage the contributions of each play tester effectively. However, the speaker also cautions that metrics should be used in tandem with other tools, as they can sometimes be misleading.
 - *For us:* The team should combine active and passive playtesting methods to gather comprehensive data. This includes both direct feedback from playtesters and anonymous data collection to ensure a well-rounded understanding of the game's balance and player experience.

- **12:30 The early access model allowed for significant improvements in metric collection and player feedback, leading to a more balanced and complete game.** *(Playtesting & metrics, medium)*
 - The speaker states that launching into early access with a balanced and near-complete game was a game-changer. This approach allowed for a larger player base, providing more valuable metric data and a wider skill range. The weekly update schedule during early access was influenced by prior development cycles and was beloved by players, establishing that the game was subject to constant iteration and balance tweaks.
 - *For us:* Consider an early access model or beta testing phase to gather a larger player base and more valuable metric data. This can lead to a more balanced and complete game, especially if the team can maintain a consistent update schedule.
- **20:16 The developers adopted an iterative approach to game development, constantly changing and improving the game based on player feedback.** *(Playtesting & metrics, high)*
 - The speaker emphasizes the importance of iterating and experimenting to refine the game. They mention that the game's daily mode became popular because they were not overly cautious and were able to swiftly act on player feedback. This approach was particularly effective when developing the third character, the Defect, which was the quickest to develop despite initial expectations. The iterative process allowed for rapid adjustments and improvements, such as reworking cards from one day to the next, which kept players and streamers engaged.
 - *For us:* The team should adopt an iterative approach to game development, constantly refining Dark Charterlands based on player feedback. This includes being open to swift changes and improvements, such as reworking cards or mechanics based on playtest results.
- **20:25 The game's design was heavily influenced by player feedback and metric data, which were crucial in shaping the game's features and balancing.** *(Playtesting & metrics, medium)*
 - The developers used various channels, including Discord, a metric server, and social media, to gather player feedback. This direct connection to the player base allowed them to understand what features were desired and to make informed decisions. For example, the Defect character was developed quickly because the developers had already designed two characters and had established streams of player feedback and metric data. The speaker also mentions that balancing the Defect live in early access was a great experience, highlighting the success of their approach.
 - *For us:* Utilize various channels to gather player feedback, including Discord, social media, and in-person events. This direct connection to the player base will help in understanding what features are desired and making informed decisions about the game's design and balance.

- **31:45 The speaker discusses the emotional impact of handling player feedback.**

(Playtesting & metrics, low)

- The speaker acknowledges the emotional load of receiving constant feedback, noting that not all feedback is created equally. They mention that they have developed a system to filter out toxic or repetitive feedback, focusing instead on detailed and constructive input. The speaker also highlights the importance of recognizing valuable feedback from specific players and using it to improve the game.
- *For us:* The team should develop a system to filter out toxic or repetitive feedback, focusing on detailed and constructive input. This will help in managing the emotional load of constant feedback and using it effectively to improve the game.

Hearthstone: How to Create an Immersive User Interface (GDC 2015)

Hearthstone team · 151,897 views

Summary: The video features Derek Sakamoto, a senior user interface designer for Hearthstone, who delves into the creative process behind designing an immersive and physical user interface for the game. He discusses the importance of finding a guiding muse, the benefits and challenges of a physical UI, and the collaborative, iterative design process. The video also touches on the influence of UI design on gameplay mechanics and the adaptation of the game for mobile platforms, concluding with a brief Q&A.

Lesson for us: The most important lesson for the team is to focus on creating a cohesive and immersive experience through a clear guiding muse and an iterative design process that emphasizes the physicality of the game elements.

- **The development of Hearthstone's UI involved a collaborative and iterative process, with input from various team members including designers, programmers, and artists.** *(Onboarding & complexity, medium)*

- The speaker describes a team effort involving a design director, art director, 3D artist, designer, and tech artist. The UI design process is iterative, starting with wireframing and progressing through programming, 2D design, and 3D modeling. The team works together to ensure that the UI is functional and visually appealing, with design changes often influencing gameplay mechanics.
- *For us:* Foster a collaborative and iterative design process involving all relevant team members, including designers, artists, and programmers. This approach can help ensure that the physical cards and other UI elements are both functional and visually appealing.

- **0:58 The concept of a 'seed' is crucial for guiding the design direction of a game's user interface.** *(Onboarding & complexity, high)*
 - Sakamoto explains that a 'seed' serves as a muse or inspiration for the design team, providing a clear direction for the game's UI. He illustrates this with early prototypes of Hearthstone that lacked a cohesive vision. The 'seed' concept helped the team create a unified and immersive experience. For Hearthstone, the seed was a vision of a magical, physical world that players could interact with, which was inspired by a 3D artist's video. This seed grew into a tree of ideas, branching out into various elements of the game's UI, such as the tavern setting and the physicality of the cards.
 - *For us:* The team should identify a clear 'seed' or guiding muse for Dark Characterlands' design to ensure a cohesive and immersive experience. This seed should inform all aspects of the game, from the physical cards to the overall theme and mechanics.
- **1:20 The design process for Hearthstone involved exploring various prototypes and concepts before settling on the final UI.** *(Onboarding & complexity, medium)*
 - Sakamoto shares several early prototypes and concepts for Hearthstone, including a world map with unlockable regions, a flash prototype, and various UI elements like matchmaking screens and loading screens. These prototypes helped the team refine their vision and ultimately led to the immersive and physical UI design that Hearthstone is known for. The process involved iterating on ideas and embracing physicality to create a cohesive and engaging user experience.
 - *For us:* Encourage an iterative design process with multiple prototypes to refine the vision for Dark Characterlands. This approach can help the team identify the most engaging and cohesive design elements for the game.
- **7:53 Embracing physicality in UI design makes the game feel more valuable and immersive.** *(Onboarding & complexity, high)*
 - Sakamoto discusses the trend towards flat UI design but argues that physicality can enhance the user experience. He explains that physical elements make the game feel more valuable and relatable, as players can understand the worth of objects like gold and gems. This is particularly important for a free-to-play game like Hearthstone, where respecting players' time and money is crucial. The physicality of the cards, for example, is designed to replicate the joy of opening a pack of cards, complete with visual and auditory cues.
 - *For us:* Emphasize the physicality of the cards and the overall game experience to make Dark Characterlands feel more valuable and immersive. This can be achieved through tactile and visual design elements that enhance the player's connection to the game world.

- **10:07 The physical UI design of Hearthstone enhances the player experience by making the game feel cohesive and immersive.** (*Onboarding & complexity, high*)
 - The speaker explains that the physical UI elements, such as cards that tilt and dust that flies up when tapped, create a magical and immersive experience. This design choice makes the game feel more cohesive, even if players do not consciously realize it. The physicality of the UI, particularly when played with touch, enhances the sense of being part of the game world. The speaker also mentions that the over-the-shoulder appeal of the game is crucial for attracting new players, as it makes the game visually interesting and inviting.
 - *For us:* Focus on creating a cohesive and immersive experience through physical UI elements, such as the design of the cards and the overall aesthetic of the game. This can enhance the player's sense of being part of the game world.
- **17:29 The UI design team at Hearthstone is given equal importance to game design, ensuring a cohesive and immersive player experience.** (*Onboarding & complexity, medium*)
 - The speaker highlights that UI design is treated as a first-class citizen in the development process, receiving equal attention to game design. This approach ensures that the UI enhances the overall player experience. The team collaborates closely, with UI designers providing mockups that inform game design decisions. This iterative process helps identify and mitigate complications early on, ensuring a more cohesive and immersive game experience.
 - *For us:* Ensure that the design of the physical cards and other UI elements is given equal importance to the game mechanics. This collaborative approach can help create a more immersive and cohesive player experience.
- **28:32 The UI design in Hearthstone significantly influenced the game's design and mechanics, with the two aspects informing each other throughout development.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - The speaker mentions that the UI design and game design progressed simultaneously, with each informing the other. For example, the design of the priest hero power was changed based on UI requirements. The speaker also notes that the game's flow and mechanics were adjusted based on UI considerations, such as the decision to prevent players from making moves during their opponent's turn.
 - *For us:* Ensure that the design of the physical cards and other UI elements informs the game mechanics and vice versa. This iterative process can help create a more cohesive and engaging game experience.

Balancing Mechanics for Your Card Game's Unique Power Curve (GDC 2018)

Dylan Mayo (The Pokemon Company) · 146,128 views

Summary: The video explores the concept of power curves in card games, using examples from Hearthstone, Magic: The Gathering, Pokémon, and Clash Royale to illustrate how cost and power balance affect gameplay and strategy. It also delves into the challenges of balancing collectible object games and the unique mechanics that differentiate various card games.

Lesson for us: The power curve of a card game is heavily influenced by its costing and resource management systems, and understanding these dynamics is crucial for balancing and designing meaningful gameplay.

- **Pokémon has a unique power curve due to its evolution mechanics and the cost structure of its cards.** (*Costing & balance, medium*)
 - In Pokémon, cards have different stages of evolution, and each stage requires a specific number of turns to evolve. This means that the power curve is not linear but rather has chunks of power at different stages. Additionally, Pokémon cards have a cost that is paid on the back end, meaning players do not pay the cost upfront but rather when they lose that resource. This unique structure affects the design and power of cards in Pokémon, making it different from games like Magic and Hearthstone.
 - *For us:* Consider unique mechanics like evolution stages in Pokémon to create a non-linear power curve. This could involve cards that become more powerful over time or require specific conditions to be met.
- **2:42 The cost and power of cards in Hearthstone are balanced to create a unique power curve.** (*Costing & balance, high*)
 - Dylan explains that in Hearthstone, the cost of a card determines when it can be played, and its power determines its effectiveness. The power curve in Hearthstone is not linear; as the cost of cards increases, the power they provide increases at a higher rate. This means that more expensive cards need to be significantly more powerful to justify their cost. For example, Dr. Boom, a seven-cost card, is more powerful than Leeroy Jenkins, a five-cost card, plus two additional mana. This non-linear power curve ensures that games remain dynamic and that players have meaningful choices throughout the game.
 - *For us:* Ensure that more expensive cards in Dark Charterlands provide significantly more power to justify their cost, maintaining a non-linear power curve. This encourages dynamic gameplay and meaningful choices throughout the game.
- **6:36 The hero power in Hearthstone helps smooth out the mana curve.** (*Resource system, medium*)
 - Dylan highlights that the hero power in Hearthstone is a mechanism that helps players use all their resources each turn. For example, if a player has two mana left over after playing a four-cost card on turn six, they can use their hero power to smooth out their mana curve. This ensures that players can always make use of their available mana, adding to the game's strategic depth.
 - *For us:* Consider adding a mechanism similar to Hearthstone's hero power to help players use all their resources each turn, smoothing out the resource curve and adding strategic depth.

- **7:46 The power of a card is not just about its raw stats but also about its cost-to-power ratio.** (*Costing & balance, high*)
 - Dylan discusses how the power of a card is not solely determined by its stats but also by its cost-to-power ratio. He uses the example of War Golem and Flame Juggler to illustrate this point. While War Golem has higher stats, Flame Juggler's ability to deal damage makes it more powerful in certain situations. This ratio is crucial in evaluating a card's true power and effectiveness. Dylan also mentions that the term for this ratio is still being debated, with suggestions like 'Jedi' and 'Marx' being considered.
 - *For us:* Consider the cost-to-power ratio when designing cards. A card's true power is not just about its raw stats but also about its effectiveness in various situations. This ratio is crucial for evaluating a card's balance.
- **10:16 Magic: The Gathering has a more complex mana system compared to Hearthstone, allowing for greater granularity in card balancing.** (*Resource system, medium*)
 - Magic: The Gathering requires specific colors of mana to play certain cards, which adds complexity to the game. For example, the card Tydings requires three of any mana and then specifically blue mana to play, while Sliver Queen requires one of five different colors. This complexity allows for more nuanced balancing of cards, as designers can adjust the mana cost and effects to fine-tune the power level. In contrast, Hearthstone has a simpler mana system where all cards of a certain cost are played the same way, regardless of their effects.
 - *For us:* Explore different resource management systems to add complexity and granularity to card balancing. This could involve using different types of resources or requiring specific resources for certain cards.
- **11:40 The power curves in Magic: The Gathering and Hearthstone differ significantly due to their respective mana systems.** (*Costing & balance, medium*)
 - In Hearthstone, players generate one mana crystal every turn, ensuring a steady increase in available mana. This means that low-cost cards need to be more powerful to incentivize playing them early. In contrast, Magic: The Gathering does not guarantee a new mana source each turn, requiring players to draw specific cards to increase their mana pool. This makes higher-cost cards in Magic more powerful, as they are harder to play and thus more impactful when they are played.
 - *For us:* Design the resource system in Dark Charterlands to influence the power curve. For example, if resources are harder to acquire, higher-cost cards should be more powerful to reflect their rarity.

- **21:21 The granularity of card costs and stats significantly impacts game balance and design.** (*Costing & balance, high*)
 - The speaker discusses how the granularity of card costs and stats affects game balance. In Pokémon, the smallest number often used was one, which is problematic because the next number, two, is twice as large, making small adjustments difficult. This led to a rebalancing effort in the Black and White set, where base HP and damage were increased to create a new normal. The speaker also compares this to miniatures games like Warhammer, where costs are more granular, allowing for finer adjustments. This granularity is crucial in card games because small numbers can be very dangerous and impact the overall balance of the game.
 - *For us:* Pay close attention to the granularity of card costs and stats. Small numbers can significantly impact game balance, so consider increasing base values to allow for finer adjustments.
- **25:02 Different card games have unique resource management systems that affect their power curves.** (*Resource system, medium*)
 - The speaker compares the resource management systems of Hearthstone, Magic: The Gathering, and the original Warcraft card game. In Hearthstone, players have a constant resource generation that increases every turn, while in Magic, players look for specific resource generators. The original Warcraft card game had a mechanic where any card from the hand could be played as a resource, making it closer to Magic in terms of resource management but still different from both Hearthstone and Magic. The speaker also notes that the typing system in Magic adds another layer of granularity, allowing for more powerful cards within the same deck.
 - *For us:* Explore different resource management systems to create a unique power curve. Consider how resources are generated and used, and how this affects the balance and strategy of the game.

Hearthstone: 10 Bits of Design Wisdom (GDC 2014)

Eric Dodds (Hearthstone) · 134,456 views

Summary: The video features Eric Dodds, the game director of Hearthstone, who discusses the game's design principles and philosophy, emphasizing accessibility, emotional impact, and player experience. He highlights key design choices, such as simplifying complex mechanics, using familiar terminology, and embracing the digital medium to create tactical depth and immediate fun for new players. Dodds also delves into the importance of emotional design, the impact of randomness, and the significance of 'little victories' in player versus player games, as well as the enjoyment and strategy of playing 1-turn kill decks.

Lesson for us: The most important lesson from this video is the significance of designing for immediate fun and accessibility, while also considering the emotional impact of gameplay mechanics on players.

- **The game design prioritizes immediate fun for new players, ensuring a smooth learning curve.** (*Onboarding & complexity, high*)
 - The speaker emphasizes the importance of making the game immediately fun for new players. This involves keeping text short and using visual cues to help players understand the game quickly. The goal is to teach players enough to start playing the real game without overwhelming them with too much information upfront. The design team aimed to create an introductory experience that gets players into the game quickly and painlessly, allowing them to learn more as they play.
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that Dark Charterlands is immediately fun for new players. This involves keeping instructions concise and using visual cues to help players understand the game quickly, allowing them to learn more as they play.
- **10:00 The primary goal in designing Hearthstone was to make collectible card games more accessible to a broader audience by simplifying complex mechanics.** (*Onboarding & complexity, high*)
 - The speaker emphasizes that traditional collectible card games are often intimidating due to their complexity. To address this, the design team aimed to create a game that everyone could understand and start playing immediately. This involved questioning and simplifying fundamental aspects of collectible card games, such as turn phases and resource management. The goal was to remove complexity without sacrificing the depth of play, ensuring that the game remained engaging for both new and experienced players.
 - *For us:* The team should simplify the core mechanics of Dark Charterlands to make it accessible to new players. This includes streamlining the turn phases and resource management, ensuring that players can start playing quickly without being overwhelmed by complexity.
- **10:46 Hearthstone's design simplified traditional collectible card game mechanics, such as turn phases and resource management, to enhance accessibility and gameplay speed.** (*Turn structure & pacing, high*)
 - The speaker explains that traditional collectible card games often have multiple turn phases, each with specific rules and actions. Hearthstone simplified this by having only one phase per turn, allowing players to do whatever they want in any order. This not only made the game easier to understand but also added tactical depth. Additionally, the game automated resource management by providing resources automatically each turn, rather than requiring players to include resource cards in their decks. This simplification sped up gameplay and made the game more exciting by focusing on minions and spells rather than resources.
 - *For us:* Dark Charterlands should focus on a single phase per turn to enhance accessibility and gameplay speed. This approach can add tactical depth by allowing players to act in any order during their turn, similar to Hearthstone's design.

- **31:25 The game design prioritized using familiar mechanics and terminology to ensure players understand the game without extensive explanation.** (*Onboarding & complexity, high*)
 - The speaker emphasizes the importance of using familiar concepts, such as cards and their associated actions (shuffling, drawing, playing, discarding), to make the game intuitive. They also discuss the significance of using common terms like 'attack' and 'health' for minions, and 'charge' for the offensive trait, to avoid confusing players. This approach helps players quickly grasp the game's mechanics and reduces the need for extensive tutorials.
 - *For us:* Dark Charterlands should use familiar mechanics and terminology to make the game intuitive. This includes using common terms for actions and traits, reducing the need for extensive tutorials and helping players grasp the game's mechanics more quickly.
- **39:31 The randomness in Hearthstone's Arena mode creates unique and memorable stories.** (*Luck & randomness, medium*)
 - The speaker discusses how the Arena mode in Hearthstone, where players draft cards and play until they lose three games or win twelve, leads to unique and memorable stories. The randomness of the card drafts can result in combinations of cards that are not possible in the ranked game, creating interesting and unpredictable gameplay experiences. The speaker emphasizes that these stories are important for the health of the game.
 - *For us:* The draft mechanic in Dark Charterlands can create unique and memorable stories. The team should embrace this randomness to enhance the gameplay experience, similar to Hearthstone's Arena mode.
- **41:08 Hearthstone's design emphasizes emotional responses over mechanical balance.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - The speaker highlights that emotional design is crucial in Hearthstone. They mention that the emotional state of players is more important than mechanical design or high-level balance. For instance, they changed the text from 'perfect opponent' to 'worthy opponent' to improve the emotional response when a player gets matched with someone. They also discuss how certain mechanics, like discard, were avoided because of the negative emotional impact they have on opponents. The speaker provides examples of how they balance cards based on emotional feedback rather than pure mechanical balance, such as increasing the cost of the 'mind control' card to reduce its emotional negativity.
 - *For us:* The team should consider the emotional impact of randomness in Dark Charterlands. While some randomness can create unique stories, it's important to balance it to avoid negative emotional responses from players.

- **49:02 The speaker discusses the unique experience and balance challenges of 1-turn kill decks in Hearthstone.** (*Costing & balance, medium*)
 - The speaker explains that 1-turn kill decks in Hearthstone are designed to prevent the opponent from doing anything for a while, then suddenly kill them in one turn. These decks are fun and challenging to play but can feel unfair to the opponent, who may feel like they didn't get any little victories before losing. The speaker mentions that the balance team has been looking at the effects of these decks and making changes to address these issues.
 - *For us:* The team should be aware of the balance challenges posed by high-risk, high-reward strategies in multiplayer games. While these strategies can be fun, they may feel unfair to opponents. The team should monitor and address these issues to maintain a balanced and enjoyable experience for all players.

Designing Race for the Galaxy (GDC 2018)

Tom Lehmann · 104,774 views

Summary: The video explores the design and mechanics of the strategic card game 'Race for the Galaxy,' with its creator Tom Lehmann discussing the game's unique mechanics, strategic depth, and economic principles. The video delves into the evolution of game design from Puerto Rico to Race for the Galaxy, highlighting the importance of player agency and the elimination of 'left-right binding.' It also covers the strategic tension between incremental gains and big combos, the iterative design process, and the considerations for different player types and accessibility in game design.

Lesson for us: The most important lesson from this video is the significance of player agency and strategic depth in game design, achieved through mechanisms like simultaneous action selection and economic principles that enhance decision-making.

- **3:17 Race for the Galaxy features simultaneous action selection and multiple victory conditions, creating strategic depth.** (*Turn structure & pacing, high*)
 - The game allows players to select their actions secretly and simultaneously, with only the chosen phases occurring in each round. This mechanic ensures that every round is different and encourages strategic planning. The game can end in two ways: when a player has 12 or more cards in their empire or when the communal victory point pool is emptied. This dual end condition creates strategic tension, as players must decide whether to invest in a victory point engine, focus on developing and settling their empire, or adopt a hybrid strategy.
 - *For us:* Consider implementing simultaneous action selection to ensure each round is dynamic and encourages strategic planning. This could be integrated into the COMMIT phase where players secretly place units. Additionally, explore multiple victory conditions to create strategic tension, such as hidden objectives that players can pursue alongside the main goal of becoming the Regent.

- **10:54 The game's design incorporates economic principles, such as opportunity cost, to enhance strategic decision-making.** (*Resource system, high*)
 - In Race for the Galaxy, players pay for cards by discarding others, making each card in their hand an opportunity that could be used or not. This concept is tied to opportunity cost, where the value of something is not just the resources spent but also what could have been done instead. This principle is applied to various real-life scenarios, such as choosing electives in college or attending seminars, to illustrate how it influences decision-making in the game.
 - *For us:* Incorporate economic principles like opportunity cost into the design. For example, make players discard cards to pay for new ones, emphasizing the value of each card in their hand. This can add depth to decision-making in the MUSTER phase.
- **18:35 The design of Race for the Galaxy was influenced by the speaker's experience with Puerto Rico and the need to eliminate 'left-right binding' in game mechanics.** (*Turn structure & pacing, high*)
 - The speaker discusses how the action mechanism in Puerto Rico, a classic Euro game, constrained the next player's options due to 'left-right binding.' This phenomenon, where one player's actions significantly affect the next player, was a design flaw that the speaker aimed to eliminate in Race for the Galaxy. The speaker decided to implement simultaneous action selection, giving players more agency and allowing the game to evolve in many directions. This decision was influenced by the speaker's experiences with five-player games of Puerto Rico, where the game's mechanics often led to unfair advantages for certain players.
 - *For us:* Avoid 'left-right binding' by ensuring that players' actions do not overly constrain the next player's options. The simultaneous action selection in the COMMIT phase can help mitigate this issue, giving players more agency and allowing the game to evolve in many directions.
- **29:41 The game Race features simultaneous action selection, which can lead to bluffing, gambling, and strategic interactions among players.** (*Multiplayer & politics, medium*)
 - The speaker highlights that the simultaneous action selection in Race leads to interesting player interactions. Players can bluff by calling phases strategically to refill their hands or to pressure opponents. Additionally, the game includes leaking and blunting effects, where players can influence each other's strategies by placing certain cards on the table.
 - *For us:* Leverage simultaneous play to speed up multiplayer games. Ensure that the game flow is smooth by minimizing synchronization points, such as during the CONTEST phase where Marches resolve in parallel.

- **36:05 The game design philosophy emphasizes strategic tension between incremental gains and big combos.** (*Costing & balance, high*)
 - The speaker discusses two main strategies in game design: one involving small, incremental powers that gradually build an edge over the opponent, and another involving big combos that require staving off defeat until the combo is assembled and played. The speaker prefers games with lots of tough decisions and good strategic tension, placing them on the spectrum closer to incremental gains. Examples like 'Glory to Rome' are mentioned, where players use discard piles to assemble combos, highlighting the sudden shift from control to victory.
 - *For us:* Create strategic tension between incremental gains and big combos. Design cards and abilities that offer both small, incremental advantages and powerful combos that require strategic planning to execute. This can be integrated into the EDICTS phase where one-shot Edicts can provide significant advantages.
- **47:58 The design of cards should appeal to various player types, including Spike, Johnny, and Timmy players.** (*Card & mechanic design, medium*)
 - The speaker mentions that cards should be designed to appeal to different player types, as described by Mark Rosewater's classic article on Magic player types. For example, efficient cards appeal to Spike players who value winning on a high percentage, while creative win conditions appeal to Johnny players. Big effects appeal to Timmy players who enjoy powerful moves. The speaker also mentions that the game should have multiple winning strategies to keep it interesting and balanced.
 - *For us:* Design cards and abilities that appeal to different player types. Ensure that the game has multiple winning strategies to keep it interesting and balanced. This can be achieved by offering a variety of draft archetypes and abilities that cater to different playstyles.

Luck in Games (ITU Copenhagen)

Richard Garfield (Magic) · 62,708 views

Summary: The video features Richard Garfield, creator of Magic: The Gathering, exploring the role of luck in games, distinguishing it from skill, and discussing its impact on gameplay and player satisfaction. Garfield uses various game examples to illustrate how luck can be introduced and balanced with skill, and how understanding the audience is crucial in game design. The discussion also touches on the evolution of games and the maturity of the audience over time.

Lesson for us: The team should carefully balance luck and skill in Dark Charterlands, introducing luck to make the game accessible and engaging, while gradually reducing it as the player base matures to emphasize skill.

- **5:42 Luck can be introduced into games through various mechanisms.** (*Luck & randomness, medium*)
 - Garfield identifies several ways luck can be introduced into games, including overt randomness (dice, cards), game theory and politics (simultaneous hidden actions), other players (introducing randomness), and physical limitations (memory, accuracy, speed). He uses the example of a game where players must choose between two doors, one leading to victory and the other to defeat, to illustrate how complexity can introduce luck.
 - *For us:* Consider how to introduce luck through the draft and hidden actions in the COMMIT phase. This could add variety and unpredictability to the game, but it should be balanced carefully to avoid trivializing strategic decisions.
- **9:57 Luck is defined as uncertainty in outcome.** (*Luck & randomness, medium*)
 - Garfield defines luck as uncertainty in outcome, stating that if there is variance in how a game will turn out, there is luck involved. He acknowledges that this definition may have counterintuitive repercussions due to humans' poor understanding of true randomness.
 - *For us:* Be mindful of how players perceive randomness in the game, especially in the draft and contest phases. Ensure that the random elements are clear and that players understand the role of luck in their outcomes.
- **12:42 The role of luck in games tends to decrease over time as games mature and players seek to emphasize skill over chance.** (*Luck & randomness, high*)
 - The speaker explains that as games evolve, designers often reduce the amount of luck involved to cater to serious players who want their skill to be the primary factor in winning. Examples include early versions of chess that involved dice, backgammon with the introduction of the doubling cube, and bridge with duplicate games. The speaker also mentions that adding luck to an existing game can be challenging because it may trivialize the expertise of experienced players.
 - *For us:* As Dark Charterlands matures, consider reducing the role of luck to emphasize skill. This could involve tweaking the draft mechanics or adjusting the influence of random events in the game.
- **14:49 Adding luck to games can increase variety and prevent players from getting stuck in strategic ruts.** (*Luck & randomness, medium*)
 - The speaker argues that luck can introduce novel situations and force players to explore new strategies. This is particularly beneficial for innovators who enjoy discovering new strategic ideas. The speaker uses chess as an example, noting that players might get stuck relying on opening books and root play, making the game less interesting. By adding luck, games can remain fresh and engaging for a longer period.
 - *For us:* Introduce luck to prevent players from getting stuck in strategic ruts. This could be achieved through the use of random events or hidden actions in the COMMIT and CONTEST phases, encouraging players to explore new strategies.

- **19:47 Luck in games can protect players' egos and broaden the audience by making games more accessible to a wider range of players.** (*Luck & randomness, medium*)
 - The speaker suggests that luck can make losing a game more palatable for players, as they can attribute their loss to bad luck rather than their own shortcomings. This can be particularly important for maintaining player engagement and satisfaction. Additionally, games with more luck can attract a broader audience because they are more accessible to players of varying skill levels, including friends and family who might not be as skilled.
 - *For us:* Ensure that the game's luck elements make it accessible to a wide range of players. This could involve balancing the draft mechanics or adjusting the influence of random events to make the game more palatable for beginners.
- **24:35 The role of luck in games evolves as the audience matures.** (*Luck & randomness, high*)
 - The speaker discusses how the need for luck in games decreases over time as the audience becomes more mature and skilled. Initially, luck is important to keep the game engaging for beginners, but as players gain more experience, the game can afford to reduce luck and highlight skills more. This evolution is seen in games like Magic: The Gathering, where the introduction of mulligans and other mechanics helps to balance luck and skill.
 - *For us:* Plan for the evolution of luck in the game as the player base matures. This could involve gradually reducing the role of luck in the draft and contest phases over time.
- **26:18 Balancing luck and skill is crucial in game design.** (*Luck & randomness, high*)
 - The speaker emphasizes the importance of balancing luck and skill in game design. He suggests that games should start with more luck to appeal to a broader audience and then gradually reduce luck as the audience becomes more skilled. This balance ensures that the game remains engaging for both beginners and experienced players. The speaker also mentions that adding or removing luck from a game can be challenging and requires careful consideration.
 - *For us:* Balance luck and skill carefully in the design of Dark Charterlands. This could involve adjusting the draft mechanics, the influence of random events, or the hidden actions in the COMMIT phase to ensure that the game remains engaging for both beginners and experienced players.
- **27:25 Increasing the number of trials can reduce the impact of luck.** (*Luck & randomness, medium*)
 - The speaker suggests that increasing the number of trials in a game can help reduce the impact of luck. This is because more trials lead to regression to the mean, where the outcomes average out over time. For example, if a game involves rolling dice, having more rolls can mitigate the effect of a single lucky or unlucky roll. This approach can make the game more skill-based over time.
 - *For us:* Consider increasing the number of trials in the game to reduce the impact of luck. This could involve adding more rounds or seasons to the game, allowing players to average out their luck over time.

- **40:11 The role of luck in games can significantly impact player immersion and enjoyment.** (*Luck & randomness, medium*)
 - Garfield explains that luck in games can introduce variety and bring players back for more, as unusual situations can be intriguing. However, he also notes that luck can be dissatisfying if it leads to a sense that a player's efforts were meaningless, such as losing a long game on a die roll. He suggests that luck should be front-loaded in longer games to maintain player engagement throughout. Garfield also compares games like Starcraft and chess, noting that while Starcraft has physical limitations and luck, chess is more about memory and complexity. He emphasizes the importance of knowing one's audience and what they want in a game.
 - *For us:* Be aware of how luck can impact player immersion and enjoyment. Ensure that the game's luck elements are front-loaded in longer games to maintain player engagement throughout. This could involve adjusting the draft mechanics or the influence of random events in the early phases of the game.

PAX Dev 2018 Keynote

Ben Brode · 46,177 views

Summary: The video features Ben Brode, former game director of Hearthstone, who shares his insights on game design and development, emphasizing the importance of responsive controls, effective matchmaking, and a clear vision among team members. He also discusses strategies for maintaining player happiness, managing employee workload, and avoiding industry burnout, drawing from his personal experiences and new role in the industry.

Lesson for us: The most important lesson from this video is the significance of having a clear and shared vision among the team, especially when designing complex systems like Community Charters, and the importance of engaging directly with the community to build trust and manage expectations.

- **Having a clear and shared vision is crucial for game development teams.** (*Business & distribution, medium*)
 - The speaker emphasizes the importance of ensuring that all team members share a clear vision of what the game is and what it aims to achieve. The speaker uses the example of creating a zombie movie to illustrate how different interpretations of the same concept can lead to misalignments. The speaker suggests using imagery and concrete examples to align the team's vision and to check in regularly to ensure everyone is on the same page.
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that all members involved in creating Community Charters share a clear vision of what these rules aim to achieve. Regular check-ins can help maintain alignment among the team.

- **6:45 The time between deciding to play and actually having fun should be minimized.** (*Onboarding & complexity, high*)
 - Brode discusses the importance of reducing the time it takes for players to start having fun. He mentions various factors that can increase this time, such as log-in speed, menu navigation, and the initial gameplay experience. He provides examples of games like Clash Royale and Metamorphabet that have fast load times, and discusses how startup logos and menu animations can either enhance the game's feel or add unnecessary delay.
 - *For us:* The team should focus on streamlining the initial setup and draft process to minimize the time between deciding to play and actually having fun. This includes ensuring that the physical components are easy to handle and that the rules are quickly understandable.
- **24:37 Educating players can mitigate the Dunning-Kruger effect, reducing misinformed criticism and improving community sentiment.** (*Community, leagues & house rules, medium*)
 - The speaker discusses the Dunning-Kruger effect, where people with little experience often overestimate their knowledge and confidence. This can lead to misinformed criticism from players. By educating players and providing them with more information, developers can help reduce this effect, leading to more informed discussions and better community sentiment. The speaker shares personal experiences where educating players helped improve their understanding and reduced negative sentiment.
 - *For us:* The team should consider educating players about the design principles behind Community Charters and how to effectively use them. This can help reduce misinformed criticism and improve community sentiment around house rules.
- **29:08 Developers should engage directly with the community to build trust and manage expectations.** (*Community, leagues & house rules, medium*)
 - The speaker highlights the importance of developers engaging directly with the community. This helps build trust and manage expectations more effectively. The speaker shares an example of a bug report that was fabricated, and how the delay in responding allowed misinformation to spread. The speaker also discusses the importance of responding quickly to community feedback and being visible in community discussions.
 - *For us:* The team should engage directly with the community to build trust and manage expectations around Community Charters. This includes being visible in community discussions and responding quickly to feedback.

From Concept to Card: How to Design an Epic TCG Set

Rempton Games · 41,534 views

Summary: The video offers a detailed guide on creating a trading card game set, using Magic: The Gathering as a reference, with a focus on developing a unique theme, designing a comprehensive set structure, and the iterative process of playtesting and balancing. It encourages viewer engagement and discussion on the topic.

Lesson for us: The most important lesson for the team is the iterative nature of TCG design, emphasizing the need for a well-structured design skeleton, continuous playtesting, and a focus on unique

and memorable themes to create a balanced and engaging set.

- **1:02 The video emphasizes the importance of a unique and memorable core theme for a TCG set, which can be either mechanical (bottom-up) or flavorful (top-down).** *(Draft & set structure, medium)*
 - The speaker suggests that a good TCG set should have a core concept that ties everything together and makes the set unique. This theme can be mechanical, such as the 'lands matter' theme in Zendikar sets, or flavorful, like the Greek mythology-inspired world of Theros. The speaker also introduces a new theme idea: a world filled with bureaucracy and red tape where monsters compete in brutal office politics, which is a top-down flavor theme. The speaker also mentions that a set should have around three major themes, including at least one mechanical and one flavorful theme that tie into each other.
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that the core theme of Dark Charterlands is unique and memorable, tying into both the mechanical and flavorful aspects of the game. This will help players understand and engage with the game's world and mechanics more easily. The team should also consider having around three major themes, including at least one mechanical and one flavorful theme that tie into each other.
- **5:26 The design skeleton is a crucial outline that helps determine which cards to design and how everything fits together.** *(Draft & set structure, high)*
 - The design skeleton is described as a strong outline that helps in determining which cards are needed, which ones are already designed, and how everything in the set fits together. The speaker provides an example of a modern Magic set, which has 260 cards divided into Commons, Uncommons, Rares, and Mythic Rares. Each rarity is further divided by color and card type, ensuring that all major factions and card types are represented. The speaker also mentions the importance of designing cards at a range of different costs, especially at common and uncommon levels, to ensure a good curve. Additionally, the design skeleton should include spots for specific details known to be needed in the set, such as new mechanics and top-down tropes.
 - *For us:* The team should create a design skeleton that outlines the structure of the set, ensuring that all major factions and card types are represented. This includes designing cards at a range of different costs, especially at common and uncommon levels, to ensure a good curve. The design skeleton should also include spots for specific details known to be needed in the set, such as new mechanics and top-down tropes.

- **9:40 The video suggests starting with the most constrained cards when designing a TCG set to avoid painting oneself into a corner.** (*Card & mechanic design, high*)
 - The speaker advises starting with the cards that have the most constraints, as designing these first can help avoid ending up with no good solutions for the remaining cards. This approach ensures that the design process is more manageable and that the set remains balanced and cohesive. The speaker also mentions that every card designed adds additional limitations for the other cards, so starting with the more constrained cards can help narrow down the design space for the more open-ended designs.
 - *For us:* The team should start designing the most constrained cards first, such as those with unique abilities or specific roles in the game. This approach will help avoid ending up with no good solutions for the remaining cards and ensure that the set remains balanced and cohesive. The team should also consider the additional limitations that each designed card adds to the design space for the more open-ended designs.
- **10:26 The design process for a TCG set is iterative and involves continuous playtesting to refine and balance the cards.** (*Playtesting & metrics, high*)
 - The speaker emphasizes that designing cards in a vacuum is insufficient; playtesting is crucial. Early playtests focus on ensuring major themes are fun and clear. As the set develops, playtests shift to balancing draft archetypes and subthemes, and fine-tuning power levels. The design process is cyclical, involving creating cards, playtesting, making changes, and repeating. The design skeleton is a tool that can and should change as needed based on playtest feedback.
 - *For us:* The team should engage in continuous playtesting to refine and balance the cards in Dark Charterlands. Early playtests should focus on ensuring major themes are fun and clear. As the set develops, playtests should shift to balancing draft archetypes and subthemes, and fine-tuning power levels. The design process should be cyclical, involving creating cards, playtesting, making changes, and repeating.

What Can Video Games Learn from Collectible Card Games? (GDC 2018)

Skaff Elias · 14,654 views

Summary: The video explores the intricate design and business strategies behind collectible card games, drawing from the speaker's extensive experience with titles like Magic: The Gathering. It delves into the importance of randomness, value addition, and skill measurement in game design, as well as the impact of design decisions on game economy and player experience. The speaker also emphasizes understanding the audience and the implications of release schedules and price changes on gameplay and sales.

Lesson for us: The most important lesson from this video is the need to balance design and business considerations, ensuring that the game remains engaging and valuable to players over the long term, which is crucial for a high-depth strategy game like Dark Charterlands.

- **Limiting the number of game formats can help maintain a robust player base.**

(Community, leagues & house rules, medium)

- The speaker suggests that limiting the number of game formats can help maintain a robust player base. Too many formats can dilute the player base, making it difficult to sustain interest and social currency in any single format. The speaker notes that while having multiple formats offers different ways to play, it's important to balance this with the need to maintain a robust audience in each format.
- *For us:* The team should consider limiting the number of game formats to maintain a robust player base. Too many formats can dilute the player base, making it difficult to sustain interest and social currency in any single format, which is crucial for a multiplayer free-for-all game.

- **The speaker highlights the interconnected nature of game design and business decisions in digital games, particularly how changes in rarity and power of objects can significantly impact the game's economy.** *(Business & distribution, high)*

- The speaker explains that changes in the rarity or power of objects in a game can have significant implications for the game's economy. For example, changing the rarity of an object can affect its price and the overall cost for competitive players. Similarly, changing the power of an object can alter the average price for the game. The speaker emphasizes the importance of understanding the audience and how design decisions can impact different segments of players.
- *For us:* The team should be aware that changes in the rarity or power of cards can significantly impact the game's economy. This understanding is crucial for maintaining a balanced game and ensuring that players see the value in their purchases over time.

- **4:49 Distributed object games, which include CCGs, are characterized by hundreds of semi-individually purchasable objects that change gameplay over time.** *(Business & distribution, high)*

- Elias defines distributed object games as those containing hundreds of semi-individually purchasable objects that constitute a large portion of the gameplay. These objects change the gameplay in fundamental ways over time, making these games more like hobbies than traditional games. He highlights that these games are very difficult to construct and play but are extremely rewarding for both publishers and players.
- *For us:* The team should ensure that the costing of cards and the value they provide are balanced and clear to players. This is crucial for maintaining player engagement and satisfaction, especially since Dark Charterlands is a high-depth strategy game.

- **12:27 Clarity in the benefits of purchases is crucial for maintaining player engagement and satisfaction.** (*Business & distribution, high*)
 - The speaker emphasizes that the objects in the game must have clear benefits that players can easily understand. This clarity is essential because players, who are sophisticated and put a lot of thought into their purchases, need to see the value in what they are buying. If the benefits are not clear, players may not see the value in their purchases over time, leading to a decrease in engagement and satisfaction.
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that the benefits of purchasing cards are clear to players. This clarity is essential for maintaining player engagement and satisfaction, especially in a game where players invest significant time and resources.
- **13:51 The value of purchases in a game should increase logarithmically to ensure new players can catch up and to maintain engagement for all players.** (*Business & distribution, high*)
 - The speaker suggests that the value of purchases in a game should not increase linearly, as this would make it impossible for new players to catch up to those who have been playing for a longer time. Instead, the value should increase logarithmically, allowing new players to have a chance and ensuring that players who spend more money still see a benefit without alienating those who spend less. This approach helps in maintaining a wide range of customers and keeping them engaged.
 - *For us:* The team should design the game so that the value of purchases increases logarithmically rather than linearly. This approach will help new players catch up and maintain engagement for all players, which is essential for a game with a high depth of strategy and a multiplayer free-for-all format.
- **17:27 A certain degree of randomness is beneficial for maintaining player engagement, especially for smaller audiences.** (*Luck & randomness, medium*)
 - The speaker notes that a high degree of randomness can be beneficial for smaller audiences, as it allows players of different skill levels to compete against each other. This randomness does not diminish the skill required to play the game but adds an element that makes the game more engaging and accessible to a wider range of players. The speaker uses the example of a game like poker, where randomness allows for a more satisfying experience even when playing against better players.
 - *For us:* The team should incorporate a certain degree of randomness to maintain player engagement, especially for smaller audiences. This randomness should not diminish the skill required to play the game but should add an element that makes the game more engaging and accessible to a wider range of players.

- **20:22 Randomness in games keeps players engaged and maintains interest.** (*Luck & randomness, medium*)
 - The speaker argues that randomness is crucial for keeping players engaged. In games like poker, randomness provides feedback that keeps players involved and makes the game fun. Without randomness, players might quickly figure out the best strategies and lose interest. The speaker also notes that randomness helps in maintaining discussions about the strategic value of game elements, preventing players from coalescing too quickly on optimal strategies.
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that randomness is a key part of the game to keep players engaged. This randomness will provide feedback that keeps players involved and makes the game fun, preventing players from quickly figuring out the best strategies and losing interest.
- **40:10 Understanding your customer base and the implications of price changes is crucial for game design.** (*Business & distribution, medium*)
 - The speaker emphasizes that changing the price of a game can significantly alter the potential customer base. For instance, a game targeted at 10-year-olds might have a different price point compared to a game for mature audiences. It is essential to know who your customers are and how sensitive they will be to price changes, as this can affect the mix of objects they need to buy and the rate at which they purchase them.
 - *For us:* The team should understand their customer base and the implications of price changes. This understanding is crucial for designing a game that appeals to the target audience and maintains player engagement over time.
- **41:02 Organized play, such as tournaments and leagues, is a powerful tool in game design and marketing.** (*Community, leagues & house rules, medium*)
 - The speaker discusses how organized play can be both a marketing tool and a design element. It allows for patching the game by changing the format, which in turn affects how people play the game. The speaker also highlights the importance of considering playtimes, especially for younger audiences, and how this can impact the design of the game. For example, shorter playtimes might require changes in the mix of cards or the number of games played, which can affect the skill level and social currency of the game.
 - *For us:* The team should consider organized play as a powerful tool in game design and marketing. This can help patch the game by changing the format, which in turn affects how people play the game, and is crucial for a game with Community Charters and store League Kits.
- **46:13 Keeping objects interesting over the long term and avoiding complexity and power creep are important for maintaining player engagement.** (*Draft & set structure, high*)
 - The speaker mentions the need to rotate objects out and back in to keep the game interesting and to maintain the value of the objects. They also warn against complexity creep, where adding too many features to objects can make the game unwieldy. Power creep, where objects become increasingly powerful over time, can also lead to loss of control over the game's dynamics, such as playtime and randomness.
 - *For us:* The team should focus on keeping objects interesting over the long term and avoiding complexity and power creep. This is important for maintaining player engagement and ensuring that the game remains balanced and enjoyable over time.

- **49:40 The speaker emphasizes the importance of cross-functional collaboration within an organization to create a cohesive and valuable product for customers.**

(Business & distribution, medium)

- The speaker argues that customers do not care about the organizational structure or job roles within a company. Instead, they are concerned with the end result of the product. The speaker highlights the challenges of collaboration, especially when different departments have overlapping responsibilities. They mention that it is crucial for teams to work together effectively to create a valuable proposition for both the customer and the publisher. This is particularly important in games where the end utility of decisions is critical.
- *For us:* The team should ensure cross-functional collaboration within the organization to create a cohesive and valuable product for customers. This is crucial for a game with a high depth of strategy and a complex design, as it ensures that all aspects of the game are well-integrated and valuable to players.

Designing TCG Resource Systems

Steve Sekula (TCG Design Theory) · 5,963 views

Summary: The video is a podcast featuring Steve Sekula, the creator of the trading card game Gem Blenders, where he discusses the unique design and mechanics of his game, with a particular focus on its distinctive resource system. Sekula explores the importance of resource systems in trading card games, comparing Gem Blenders to other popular games like Hearthstone and Pokémon, and shares his design philosophy and the upcoming Kickstarter for Gem Blenders. The conversation also touches on the benefits of playing various trading card games to enhance one's understanding and skills in the genre.

Lesson for us: The most important lesson from this video is the critical role of a well-designed resource system in enhancing the depth, balance, and accessibility of a trading card game, which the team should apply to the Seals system in Dark Charterlands.

- **6:16 The resource system in Gem Blenders is integral to its gameplay, allowing players to unlock powerful abilities by blending gems.** *(Resource system, high)*

- In Gem Blenders, resources are used to unlock powerful abilities and transformations. Players collect gems and blend them to create blends, which are powerful effects that can transform heroes. This system is central to the game's mechanics and lore, making it a key feature that sets Gem Blenders apart from other trading card games. The game's resource system is designed to accumulate and unlock things as players progress, similar to how energy is used in Pokemon to unlock attacks.
- *For us:* The team should ensure that the Seals (resources) in Dark Charterlands are integral to unlocking powerful abilities and transformations, similar to how gems are used in Gem Blenders. This will add depth to the gameplay and make the resource system a key feature.

- **10:12 Resource systems are essential for balancing and adding depth to trading card games.** (*Costing & balance, high*)
 - The speaker argues that resource systems allow for varied card costs and effects, which in turn create the variance and strategic depth that players enjoy. Without a resource system, all cards would need to be relatively even to play, potentially making the game less fun. The speaker uses examples like KeyForge and Genesis to illustrate how deck-building limitations can also serve as a form of resource management.
 - *For us:* The team should design the Seals system to allow for varied card costs and effects, creating the necessary variance and strategic depth for players to enjoy. This will help balance the game and make it more engaging.
- **12:27 Gem Blenders uses a resource system that is familiar yet different, drawing inspiration from games like Magic and Pokémon.** (*Resource system, medium*)
 - The speaker explains that Gem Blenders' resource system is designed to be relatable to players of other TCGs, using mechanics similar to those in Pokémon and Yu-Gi-Oh. The game combines these familiar elements in a new way, making fusion summoning a central mechanic rather than a side one. The speaker suggests that while originality is valuable, familiarity can make a game more accessible and enjoyable.
 - *For us:* The team should aim to make the Seals system in Dark Charterlands familiar yet unique, drawing inspiration from other TCGs to make it accessible to new players while also offering a fresh experience.
- **19:38 The design of Gem Blenders prioritizes elegance and ease of resource acquisition.** (*Resource system, high*)
 - The speaker discusses the design choices behind Gem Blenders, noting that the game makes it easier to acquire resources compared to other TCGs. This design decision is intended to balance the complexity of managing multiple resources. The speaker also mentions that the community has developed standards for the number of resource cards to include in a deck, based on the specific blends and creatures used.
 - *For us:* The team should design the Seals system to be elegant and easy to acquire, balancing the complexity of managing multiple resources. This will help maintain a smooth gameplay experience.
- **20:16 Digital and physical trading card games have different resource systems that affect gameplay.** (*Resource system, high*)
 - The speaker highlights that digital games like Hearthstone have resource systems designed with digital play in mind, such as mana systems that are easier to showcase digitally. In contrast, physical games often have more impactful resource systems, like the use of lands or energies that players must manage physically. The speaker suggests that these differences can make digital resource systems seem less engaging compared to their physical counterparts.
 - *For us:* The team should leverage the physical nature of Dark Charterlands to create a more impactful resource system, ensuring that the management of Seals is engaging and tactile.

- **22:26 The design of resource systems in trading card games can significantly impact accessibility and marketability.** (*Resource system, high*)
 - The speaker discusses how the design of resource systems can affect whether new players feel they need to acquire a large number of specific cards to play the game. For example, in a game with nine different gems, players might feel they need multiple copies of each gem to build a deck. The speaker mentions that their game addresses this by providing enough gems in packages to ensure players can build a deck without needing to acquire too many cards upfront. This design choice is aimed at making the game more accessible to new players.
 - *For us:* The team should design the Seals system to be accessible to new players, ensuring that the initial packs provide enough resources to build a functional deck without requiring too many additional cards.
- **32:13 Thematic consistency is crucial for a game's resource system.** (*Resource system, medium*)
 - The speaker emphasizes that a game's resource system should blend well with its overall theme and mechanics. They use Gem Blenders as an example, where gems are a core part of the game's lore and theme, making it a natural fit. The speaker suggests that any game mechanic tied to the lore will be beneficial, but it should feel natural and elegant rather than forced. They also mention that while thematic consistency is important, gameplay benefits should take priority.
 - *For us:* The team should ensure that the Seals system in Dark Charterlands blends well with the game's overall theme and mechanics, making it a natural and elegant part of the gameplay experience.
- **36:17 Gameplay benefits should take priority over thematic consistency.** (*Resource system, high*)
 - The speaker states that while both thematic consistency and gameplay benefits are important, gameplay benefits should take priority. They suggest a 60/40 split in favor of gameplay, as an enjoyable experience is crucial. The speaker also notes that players can draw their own connections to the theme based on their gameplay experience.
 - *For us:* The team should prioritize gameplay benefits over thematic consistency when designing the Seals system, ensuring that the resource management is enjoyable and strategic.

- **52:06 Gem Blenders' resource system is designed to be unique and thematic, combining familiar elements to create a distinctive gameplay experience.** (*Resource system, high*)
 - The resource system in Gem Blenders is designed to be both thematic and familiar, combining elements that players are already accustomed to. This system allows for a high degree of creativity and flexibility in deck-building, similar to a five-color deck in Magic: The Gathering. The game encourages players to find synergies between cards that were not necessarily designed to work together, capturing the feeling of mixing different cards in a strategic way. The design choice avoids forced synergies, allowing players to experiment with various combinations.
 - *For us:* The team should design the Seals system to be both thematic and familiar, combining elements that players are accustomed to while allowing for a high degree of creativity and flexibility in deck-building.